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THE ABBEY WOOD AND THAMESMEAD

PEOPLE

The "Community Action" Award for working with the Thamesmead Community College was made to the People last year by SOLOTEC and the Bexley Education Business Partnership

Independently produced in Thamesmead by and for the community ISSN 1355-9087 Volume 6, Edition 10 May 2000

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Unite!

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

This month has seen at last, to the immense relief of so many, the neutralising of some divisive elements in our community. So now, let us unite in furthering the broad interests of the community that enriches Abbey Wood and Thamesmead

NOW let's dwell on the benefits of SRB money for the community, through the Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Partnership – the members of which are Bexley and Greenwich councils and the revamped Trust Thamesmead, headed by Julian Martin – see page eight.

EVOLVING

We at the *People* are much aware of how important it is that this paper keeps on working for this evolving community – a heavy responsibility but, *really, an enjoyable one.*

WARTS AND ALL

With the assistance of you all, we'll try to portray you all – ok, warts and all – but as you are. If you stay as you are, talented, proud and fiesty, we won't have to change what we do very much at all.

ABBEY WOOD

With much pleasure we include Abbey Wood. Both in our circulation and in our coverage. As long-time residents know, the community of Abbey Wood has been close and interwoven with Thamesmead's for many years.

EQUAL

We ask you to unite with the aim of bettering our living. A vibrant community and social activity, more *and better-paid jobs, ever-*improving schools, ordinary joes and joesses getting involved and running things and protecting what has always been most precious to the town: equal opportunities for all.

We ask the curmudgeons, the bitter-and-twisted, the cynical, the disbelieving – all of them, (honestly, we have got *some*!) to swallow it and have a look at the fine opportunities now opening for Abbey Wood and Thamesmead.

Gallions HA: town's new dream

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

On Monday, May 8, the new look of the Gallions Housing Association logo and management was announced by the GHA chair, Cllr John Fahy

A better care for the thousands of residents previously under the rule of TTL was promised by chair Cllr John Fahy at the launch of the new association's logo.

CHEQUES

He went on to present cheques to students of the Thamesmead Community College and Woolwich Polytechnic College, who had assisted in the design of the housing association's new logo.

The installation of this bright new logo on the building in Harrow Manor Way encapsulated the aspirations of so many in the community. Just like Thamesmead, it's bright, colourful and eye-catching. It represents, however, much more.

Many man/woman hours of work and negotiation has wrested from a not-too-interested government a degree of democratisation for which many had yearned. It isn't perfect by any means, but it's the best we're going to get. The future holds much potential, given community involvement.

Continued on page 10



Help ... !

PRESS RELEASE

Vandals put Gym Club out of action

ACTIVITIES at the Crossway Gymnastics Centre in Byron Close, Thamesmead, were partially halted last week after a car was set ablaze adjacent to the Centre. The newly decorated premises were destroyed by the smoke and soot that seeped into the building.

UNDAUNTED

Undaunted by this mindless act, volunteers set to work cleaning up in preparation for competitions last weekend. A complete decoration programme had been undertaken for the planned Millennium and Tenth Anniversary celebration events in June.

Tony Nell, the Head Coach, said "the kids were coming as gymnasts and going home looking like chimney sweeps!"

Equipment was damaged and the cover of the sprung floor will need to be replaced.

The whole affair has caused money problems for the Gym which is financially self-supporting, relying on members' fees to keep the facilities going. The Club opens seven days a week and specialises in physical training for special needs children and adults.

For details ring Tony Nell on 020 8312 1190.

Ed: come on people – every penny helps. These youngsters need you now!

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JOBS on pages 1, 2 and 7



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IN THE EDITOR'S OPINION



On the bus, coming along Crossway, I noticed the pink candles on the horse-chestnut trees then, walking home through Seacourt and Portmeadow I saw how richly some residents had decorated their gardens with flowers and always, always, the treasure of Thamesmead, with trees.

How rich in trees are we – so many varieties, so many colours – so many sizes!

Meanwhile, deaf old git though I am, birdsong. All the way, once away from the traffic noise of Harrow Manor Way, the swooping, staring, busy, singing presence of birds.

Yes, I'd walked past the coots' nest in Southmere Lake, and the swans, and the Canada geese. But they were noisily there.

Do you think I'm going barmy? I think it would be sad if you did, because these things I see every day are delights for everyone, if they'd but notice.

We've got lakes and canals and little parks and big parks and green, green, green, wherever you walk. Such a treasure – small wonder we've got so many people fiercely defending *our town!*

And I include Abbey Wood. Has anyone walked through the park off Grovebury Road recently? That's a delight too. The flower-lovers live all over this patch – you can see their loving care in garden after garden, plants of every description bringing rainbows of colour for us all to enjoy.

This area's getting on a bit now. The plans of the GLC – no, the *dreams* of the GLC, have come to fruition, and they've done so with the active assistance of hundreds, if not thousands of people – all those stalwarts who took the time to form the TCA, who founded Trust Thamesmead, who enabled the myriad groups in our community – they shepherded it all.

I say thanks. Thanks to them all, for all their work and sense of fun – because they kept that alive too!

All very emotional you might say – what a load of ... no, we won't go into that, but I really do think these things are important.

One day, when everyone's ignored the advice and the world's oceans have risen in exasperation and flooded this low-lying land (and they will), our children will look out over the water, studded with the tops of tower blocks, and they'll be able to say "Yes, this was quite some community here – a lesson for us all."

But today, the lesson's just as real. The way the people of this area have shown spirit, comradeship and inventiveness is a lesson to many other communities.

Just like those trees and flowers and birds and lakes it could all be left to die off, couldn't it? But you won't let that happen, will you? You're a bit too awkward for that, aren't you?

Invisible man

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

THE community lost a tireless worker on Friday, April 14 with the sudden death of Tom Chambers. Many only knew him as the husband of our own Mary Chambers MBE, the leading light behind Trust Thames-mead for over 20 years.

BACKING

What many knew and appreciated was that Mary's work for the community would not have been possible without the backing of her beloved Tom.

A memorial service was held in a packed St Paul's Church in Bentham Road, Thamesmead, on Wednesday, May 3. The cogent facts of Tom's work behind the scenes were borne out in the many tributes. Suzanne Lockett gave a very moving tribute to the work and help Tom had given her during her time at the Thamesmead Community Nursery.

SUZANNE

A door wanted fixing, so Suzanne asked Mary if she knew of a carpenter who could hang a new door in the Nursery. It was an immediate need because of the danger to the small children.

Mary called Tom, who was in the next office, and off he went with Suzanne. The door was fixed, to Suzanne's relief and to the delight of the small children gathered behind a safety barrier to watch. She said Tom, whilst working, answered many questions the youngsters fired at him – in many cases the same question, over and over again.

TED

Ted Claridge, president of the old Trust Thamesmead, recalled how Tom was described to him as the "invisible man", who was always there. If there was an odd job to do for one of the community groups, Tom was there. If you were in the office with Mary and you asked "Where's Tom?" the answer would be "Oh, he's round the Gym Club," or the School of Dance or some other community place, helping out.

He was never one to push himself forward but he was always the first in line when there was a job to do. A dab hand with a paintbrush, screwdriver or spanner, Tom could always be relied upon to do a good job for our Thamesmead community. Ted went on to mention that one of the floral tributes was in the shape of a teapot, for Tom was a past master at tea-making and keeping meetings supplied with a cuppa.

Albert Dixon of Respond spoke of Tom from the heart and Canon Chris Byers talked movingly of Tom's life.

TONY

Tony Nell attempted to speak the following words at the service, but found it too great a trial. We reproduce them here, respectfully understanding his wish to have them said: "At times like these, there are no words to express the sadness we feel. Words would seem too inadequate – they'd get in the way of our sorrow. Together we have gained love and support from one and other, a legacy passed to us through Tom.

"Tom never judged others. To him there were no important people, or unimportant people. He drew on the qualities of everyone and developed from this his own unique personality.

"And so, we have celebrated his life together, as a family, as friends, as a community. As Tom's best mate I lead with a thankyou for all your support for Mary, and for sharing his last moments with us today."

ENRICHED

Many others came, from the days that Tom knew. Among them Mair Garside, ex-GLC councillor and friend of Thamesmead. Peter Suckling, old friend and admired past worker in our midst. PC Rick Beavis, indefatigable toiler in *really* helping our young ones. Co-architects of a world Tom so enriched.

BRAVE LADY

But one little, brave, lady brought tears to many an eye. Dressed in the smart red uniform of the Gym Club, her hair dutiful for the hour, "Ollie" Aulsford, Crossway Gym Club Captain wrote, and read, this:

Tom somehow always saw the best in us
His gentle hands that did so much
yet kept their gentle, loving touch
Our Friend Tom was always there
the very first to give and share
Tom brought one of those days
with so much happiness in it
of which we will treasure every minute
There is so much love here, Tom, today
to show you're remembered
in a very special way

Ollie Aulsford

This coverage is not meant to be miserable. It is produced with, in mind, the wish to *celebrate* Tom's life. We thank, for their assistance in preparing this reportage, Freeman of Greenwich Borough Ted Claridge; "Mrs Thamesmead" Mary Chambers MBE, named on the day as "Thamesmead's greatest lady"; all those hundreds of people who took the time to support Mary in bled days and w on the Chamber wishes to send d flowers to the G & Bexley Cotta pice. Tom and M fine sons were too, and remain

While we wi Tom, he would h we get realistica life – working, a to enrich this fin nity. A job to do.

A letter from Tom Chambers' sons

LETTER

Dear Don and Rosemarie,

In many ways this is a letter we would rather not have had to write for so many reasons.

It has been a very sad time for us all, but we have gained much comfort from the generosity of love and caring we have all received, particularly for our mum, from the community of Thamesmead. What an amazing place.

How do we begin to thank so many people for so much, for the overwhelming concern over the death of our dad, Tom.

Through your paper we express our sincerest thanks for all the cards of sympathy, there were 166 in total, and the letters of condolence and floral tributes which are still arriving.

It is comforting to us that Tom was so well liked and admired for what he did, especially with children's groups in Thamesmead. Then dad always did care that children were happy and well occupied, as he did with us when we were small. We spent many happy weekends at Weybridge, fishing in the river Thames; he actually hated fishing!

He ran football clubs for local kids in Brixton. Many a time he would pack at least 10 of us into his little A40 and take us up to Raynes Park. But then he was an active sportsman himself in those days. Our mum became a "grass widow" to the teams he played for, both Saturdays and Sundays.

He was a cricket enthusiast also, playing in his later years for Erith & Belvedere Cricket Club. We looked through his score books recently which he kept with pride. He was an all rounder and his claim to fame seemed to be on one occasion taking 7 wickets for just 21 runs. He played hockey and water polo – though he never learned to swim. That was our dad, courageous and strong, yet gentle, caring and compassionate with always a thought for others.

We will m dreadfully. He w liant granddad Owen, Vicki and many ways mu was the brains b family, but Tom strength. His Service on May all really. It put i the words we a to find on this o our attempt to th people who can celebrate his lif We are reassur leave again for lands and the England that mu be alone, and you for this.

Sincerely, S Chris Chamber



"'Ere, gel, wotchyer grinnin' fer?"
"Dintcher 'ear, dey're gonna fi' us up a shower!"
"Blurry 'ell ..."
"Yeah, yer'll walk inna pub annay won't 'old noses!"

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Welcome!

If you are a new resident of Abbey Wood and Thamesmead the *Thamesmead People* welcomes you to this busy community. We strive to picture all that is happening here: the good, the bad, the ugly and most of all, the wealth of our community. We provide you with the only honest and uncensored letters pages available in the area and with the most accurate recording of events. You may treat this as *your* newspaper. We hope you will be happy here.

The *People*'s telephone number is 020 8473 0128, the fax number 020 8333 8799 and the e-mail address is people@dircon.co.uk.

Magic!

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

Gary Redding, of Thamesmead's Respond, said "Come with me, see what we do ... "

IN a moving *tour-de-force* displaying an innate ease with young people, this dynamic young man illustrated, easily, how to break the barriers with them, bringing them knowledge that explained the mysteries of the magistrates' courts.



"Owen Money" the "offender" on trial

RESPOND

A magistrate himself (how *does* he find the *time*?) Gary obviously knows the ropes, but this session put on by Respond for the Prince's Trust Volunteers organisation took the form of a mock trial (a scheme supported by Bexley Magistrates' Court).

With skilfully-prepared scripts ready for them, Gary was able to settle the young people into their roles, where they showed an ability to read and play-act that surprised.

CHOICES

The case they had to consider was of shoplifting. It demanded consideration of all aspects – with Gary explaining each one, particularly the choices open to real magistrates.

This was plainly an eye-opener for the young people. Suddenly, the apparently illogical became understandable – their grasp of the issues so excited them it was moving.

ENTHUSIASM

They entered the spirit of the occasion with enthusiasm. It's a good job for the offender that, once found guilty, hanging, drawing and quartering wasn't on the menu!

The finding of guilt displayed considerable acuity on their part. They really did reason things out – just as magistrates have to of course, but these young people did it and that was illuminating.

The whole time it was evident that Gary had the complete involvement for which both he and the Volunteers had hoped.

ORDINARY

The exercise brought home to these youngsters the fact that magistrates are ordinary people. It amazed them that magistrates are unpaid, that they do not have to have qualifications (other than to be of a fair and open mind – that's checked) and that their powers are limited.

"OPENS YOUR MIND"

The young ones gave opinions, and we've recorded those of four: Gemma Saunders, "I really enjoyed Princes Trust, I would recommend it to anyone,"; James Baker, "Opens your mind to different kinds of people,"; Dan Downey, "My favourite part was the residential at Carroty Wood," and Nancy Foran, "Done Prince's Trust, I recommend that you have a go."

CREDIT

They were a credit to themselves and the occasion was a credit both to Respond and to the Prince's Trust Volunteers.

The building was quiet (thanks to Bronze Age Way taking so much traffic from West Street) and airy, an excellent venue for this and the many other activities of the Youth and Family Centre.



The acute "prosecution" – Perry Mason, eat your heart out!

On the journeys there and back that sunny morning Gary told of the ideas and plans being worked on by the team at Respond (Thamesmead) Ltd. There is much more to come from this think-tank of an organisation – watch it, with anticipation.

THANKS

The *People* thanks the kind staff at the Centre, the Trust's Bridie, the bubbling Gary and those exciting young people. Mornings spent like that are gold-dust to brighten life.



The local (from Erith, mainly) young people, with Bridie, the Prince's Trust Volunteers Youth Worker, in the middle. Taken beside the shiny new London Borough of Bexley Youth and Family Centre in West Street, Erith

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TLC working 1

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

The Thamesmead Law Centre, established after years of hard work by people of this area, told us of recent cases it has handled ...

A Case Study. "Ms G came to the Thamesmead Law Centre in St Paul's, Bentham Road, Thamesmead, penniless and very anxious.

"She had arrived in the UK as an asylum seeker with her two children ten years ago and her claim had still not been finally processed.

"Her temporary leave to remain had expired, her benefits had been stopped as a result and she faced eviction due to non-payment of her rent.

"She was so frightened of being deported that she had not tried to get any State assistance whatsoever and was being provided for by her friends and family.

"It took a lot of time for the caseworker to get the full facts and to persuade Ms G that it was safe to so relate them.

"We arranged for emergency support from Social Services. With the help of her MP's office we managed to get her indefinite leave to remain in the UK confirmed, despite the fact that the Home Office initially claimed her case was dormant.

"We got all her benefits started again, backdated benefits of over £2,000 were paid and the eviction prevented."

HUNDREDS

This was just one of the hundreds of cases put before this essential, and volunteer-manned, service. Whilst volunteers are trained, expert legal minds are there too (of course including the respected Roselle Potts). The Law Centre approaches its official launch soon (more next month) so good wishes and deep thanks to them all. *See page 14.*

News from Broadwaters

Hi, everyone! First, many thanks to the ladies who 'phoned me in response to my article in the last edition of the paper about the problems of the youths that live in West Thamesmead.

Lady number one lives in Wren Path flats and she said how all the closing-in of the flats had not helped, as the back was still open, with only a wall that is very easy to climb to gain access to the gardens. She has called the Police a number of times and has been told "There is nothing we can do."

Lady number two hasn't lived here long. She moved here thinking how nice and quiet it is. She 'phoned me in a panic. She had gone to the local shops in her car because she felt safer. On coming out of the shop a crowd of boys abused her verbally and she was petrified and returned to the shop, where one of their young men helped her to her car. She said that she was still shaking and did not know what to do. She then remembered my article in the paper – she knew there was nothing I could do but needed to talk to someone. I listened and could understand how she felt. She said that she had two sons and that she would never allow them to terrify people like that (sorry, I didn't get your number, please get in touch).

The third lady rang to say she had something for the girls to do as well as the boys – "Baton Twirling" – a new club starting on June 19, 5–7pm on Mondays, ages five to 20, £1.50 a session. So there you go, Mums, get them along to meet Ria and Lucy. If things go well there will be more sessions.

Thanks also to the lady who 'phoned to say that she had read my column – makes me feel that I'm not writing it to myself!

Bingo has once again been mentioned – how about Monday afternoons? It would help if you can let me know if you are interested – please ring me.

Well, that's about it for this month. If you know anybody who's not getting the paper they can collect one from the Costcutters Supermarket. Many thanks to the new proprietors and good luck to them – they seem to carry everything but the kitchen sink, so give them a look-in.

Cheers for now, Jean Maslin on 020 8473 3810, the Village Hall

Unions' no to campus closure

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

As though in echo of the "Thamesmead Conscience" article this month, details of a campaign to keep Woolwich viable

TRADE UNIONISTS, students and local businesses have slammed a consultants' report recommending closure of the Woolwich and Dartford campuses of Greenwich University.

They claim that if the recommendation is implemented it would spell disaster. In the case of Woolwich it is claimed that it would be the final nail in the coffin for the once thriving town.

PLEDGE

The biggest trade unions representing staff at Greenwich University, the National Association of Teachers in Further Education (NATFE), which represents the academic staff, and Unison, which represents the support staff, have pledged to campaign to prevent the closures.

The consultants' document, "Campus options appraisal", was presented to the University's Finance and Estates Committee in February. It claims that the closure of the Woolwich site would save between £40-50 million over the next 10 years with a further £10 million savings if the Dartford site is also closed. It recommends that the University "should seriously consider closure of both Woolwich *and Dartford campuses*".

HIT HARD

The Woolwich University campus currently caters for 4,288 full time equivalent students. It employs almost one thousand academic and support staff. Up to 80% of students live within a five-mile radius of the Woolwich site and the overwhelming majority of the support staff lives locally. Campaigners claim the loss of thousands of students from the area coupled with the potential loss of almost a thousand jobs at the University would hit the local economy hard.

RUMOURS

Following the meeting at which the report was first considered, rumours spread among staff and students that plans were afoot to close the Woolwich and Dartford campuses. Unison wrote to the University Secretary in mid-March seeking clarification as to what, precisely, was happening.

Having not received a reply, the secretaries of both Unison and NATFE wrote to staff at the Woolwich site on March 30 expressing their concerns and outlining their pledge to campaign to keep the campus open.

STATEMENT

A management statement claimed that "The University of Greenwich is at the early stages of a review to ensure that it is making the best use of buildings and estate. In particular, the University wishes to maximise use of its new campus in historic buildings at Maritime Greenwich. Possible options include reducing the number of campuses from five to four or possibly three. As remaining campuses become more fully occupied, we may therefore be able to further improve services and facilities on each.

"The outcome of the review is not expected for some months and there will be extensive consultations with staff, local authorities, businesses and other relevant bodies before any relevant decisions are taken. In any event, the University is likely to remain on all its current sites for at least the next three to five years.

"It is not true we are planning to close either *Dartford* or Woolwich. Absolutely no decisions have been taken. An external consultants' report suggested that we consider the case for focusing on just three or four campuses. But the current review is considering use of space, and future needs in all our buildings."

REMINDERS

Peter Kavanagh, the Unison branch secretary, told the *Thamesmead People* that Unison was delighted that there would be full consultation, but pointed out that the Union had written to the University management on behalf of its members on March 17 seeking clarification, had since sent two reminders and had had only recently received a reply simply telling the Union that no decision had yet been made.

CLOSURE

Unison respected the fact that no decisions had been made but Mr Kavanagh pointed out that a feasibility study would presumably be based on the recommendations made in the consultants' report. "The purpose, we can only assume, is to establish how the report can be implemented." He went on to point out that the report categorically recommended the closure of the Woolwich and Dartford sites.

When it was pointed out that the management had claimed that there would be no change for at least three to five years Mr Kavanagh acknowledged the point. However he went on to point out that the purpose of the Union's campaign was to persuade the court of governors not to make the decision to close the Woolwich site.

CAMPAIGN

Mr Kavanagh pointed out that the campaign had already written to all councillors, local MPs and MEPs. There were plans for a leaflet and poster campaign and the unions were hoping to involve the Bexley and Woolwich Traders' Association and the Woolwich Black Traders' Forum.

Mr Kavanagh said that the campaigners were hopeful that posters against the closure proposals would be displayed in shops, particularly in the Woolwich area, and that petitions would be available inside shops.

Window on Dagenham

TRADE UNIONIST

"AS you've already heard, Ford announced the closure in 18 months of the Dagenham PTA - assembly plant. Half the plant going this year (one shift), the rest in November 2001."

£20,000

"They have actually got 1,800 volunteers for this year's off-load of jobs. They are offering £15,000 on top of statutory entitlement, *ie*, someone with only a few years can go out with, say, £20,000.

"Half of the shop stewards have volunteered, including senior stewards. Leftish Convenor S**** R**** has been out sick and has resigned this last week. He is also Secretary of the biggest TGWU branch, but hasn't held a meeting for six months."

CHAOS

"In general, inplant unions are in chaos – each plant looking after "its own" – since Dagenham the panel of estate stewards no longer meets, having fallen out over such things as the race scandals, truck drivers, *etc*.

"The whole area is affected, knock-on of job losses with small manufacturers and the local dock being hit. For example Welbeck, at the *Volunteer* roundabout, Barking, who supply rolled steel for car bodies."

SUSPICION

"The suspicion is that Ford's strategy is to clear out all Ford employees from the plant which has recently had £400 million invested(!) and it will be reopened as a 'contract' plant under a different name doing Ford work under contract.

"Lower wages, worse conditions, *etc*.

"This would fit in with Ford plans to be a marketing company rather than a manufacturing one. The rate of profit in car production is generally low, say 3 or 4 % return on investment of billions, while car dealers have mark-ups of 30% and make nothing, they just wheel cars in one door and out the other.

"Jack Nasser, Ford boss on £10m a year, recently made a speech saying that they wanted to contract out assembly."

SHUTTING PLANTS

"Nasser made his name shutting down Ford Australia plants. There is a lot of talk about fighting the closure, but the union leaders in general talk a lot of nonsense about how good and compliant a workforce we are, and Livingstone only prattles on about the 'overvalued' pound (worth nothing now), he wants to devalue our wages *etc* to make us 'attractive' to bosses.

"There are workers who want to fight the closure and are thinking about how. Recent mass leafleting by the SWP got about 4 Ford workers to a meeting, with all their 'strike now, occupy' bluster. Keith S."

Ed: This local contributor is giving just a glimpse of the picture of present-day industrial life. The old bogey of "selling jobs" appears not to have died.

On-line Parkway

PRESS RELEASE

AS this edition prints, John Austin MP is opening Thamesmead's Parkway Primary School's new computer suite and will watch it go on-line to the Web for the first time. Pictures and story next month.

REMEMBER THE SPECIAL PEOPLE IN YOUR LIFE

When trouble comes your soul to try
you love the friend who just stands by

Perhaps there's nothing he can do
the thing is strictly up to you

For there are troubles all your own
and paths the soul must tread alone

Times when love can't smooth the road
nor friendship lift the heavy load

But just to know you have a friend
who will stand by until the end

Whose sympathy through it all endures
whose warm handclasp is always yours

It helps some way to pull you through
although there's nothing he can do

And so with fervent heart you cry
God bless the friend who just stands by.

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Local man's art exhibition

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

Brian De Souza, chair of the Thamesmead Arts Club, had a fortnight's exhibition of his work in the foyer of Crayford's Geoffrey Whitworth Theatre

CONSIDERATELY taken over to Crayford by Brian, we wondered how this theatre would be found. It's not that far away, but it's certainly tucked well into a housing estate!

It is a delight. Wholly unexpectedly, a box-like building hiding behind back gardens, it contains a welcoming foyer (very busy on the Tuesday evening we attended), where Brian's pictures were on display.

IMPRESSIVE

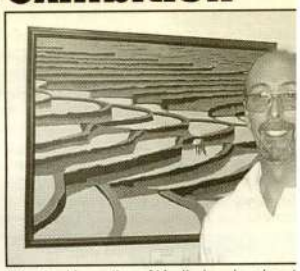
Most readers will have missed this chance to see them, because the show will have ended by the time this is read, but the work of local man, community activist and long-time supporter Brian is *very* impressive.

GREEN DANCERS

We were particularly impressed by the vivid image of what we've called the "Green Dancers" – pictured – it *is* for sale (as are Brian's other works) – we feel there is a natural place for this and other of Brian's works in decorating our community buildings and meeting places. Come on now, will someone show some imagination?

CREDIT

Credit is due to the Theatre – it recognised the talent and put it on show. Excellent. But there's much more to the Theatre than that, as readers could guess. It has a rare "people-based" feel about it, deserving of a deeper coverage than is possible this month. However, we have had preliminary chats and are going to visit again (with the camera) to see what it's about.



Brian beside another of his displayed works – t beer glass in his hand is out of shot!



Two of the Gallions HA EMB members admiring Brian's work, Green Danc

So look forward to that – now, who's going to talk to Brian about getting some of his work enriching our town? It's local talent, isn't it?



The Ayatolla

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PUT A CROOK AWAY!

'Hurrah for England and St George!'

PRESS RELEASE

ON St George's Day (April 23) local Tories from Bostall and Christchurch branches held a traditional luncheon of roast beef, followed by apple pie and custard to celebrate the patron saint of England.

The English flag and English rose were much in evidence and young and new members joined more mature members in celebrating the history of England. Held at the Bexleyheath Conservative Club was attended by 50 local activists, who were joined by guests David Evennett, the prospective parliamentary candidate for Bexleyheath and Crayford and his wife Marylin, Bostall Cllr John Wilkinson and Christchurch Cllr Sharon Massey.



Pictured are the top table guests, standing: Don Massey, Cllr Sharon Massey, Dacvid Evennett, Shirley Vick and Cllr John Wilkinson; seated, baby Victoria Massey Beth Massey and edna Bassett

£13.63 a year for school clothing grants!

PRESS RELEASE

LABOUR councillors on Bexley Council proposed doubling the grant for pupil clothing and uniforms at the April Council meeting. The Conservatives rejected this, out of hand.

MEANEST

Cllr Trevor Perrin said that this was the meanest cut to make. This cut hit the lowest income families the hardest. He stated that the average cost of a full school uniform is in the region of £130 – "the grant will only cover approaching 25% of the actual cost."

Cllr Mike French stated that the £37.50 was not enough to purchase one uniform. Only one grant was given in each Key Stage. With only four grants in 11 years if the pupil leaves school at sixteen, this equates to £13.63 a year.

SCROOGE

Even Scrooge, he said, would have difficulty justifying such a small amount. "Yet again the Conservative group has shown disregard for the most vulnerable members of our society."

ASSIST

The Conservatives had stated, at the Education and Leisure meeting, that the grant was only to *assist* with the purchase of a uniform, and that you could buy second-hand uniforms from most schools.

Ed: any comments?

Tony Cotter, Chief Executive and the staff of the Gallions Housing Association, welcome the residents of Thamesmead to a new and brighter future

On April 28 the formal transfer of business from Thamesmead Town Ltd to Gallions Housing Association was successfully completed

(see details on page 10)

Gallions is looking forward to working closely with the community in continuing to set the agenda

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Harrow Manor Way
Thamesmead
SE2 9XH

Telephone 020 8310 1500
Fax 020 8310 1811

Southmere Green

SAINTS' RESIDENTS' ASSOCIATION

RESIDENTS may have noticed in last month's edition of the *People* that Tilfen has applied to build workshop units and a large roads infrastructure on Southmere Green.

Lidl is building its monster warehouse in Belvedere so Tilfen is desperate to have the Green *developed as soon as* possible.

Residents of South Thamesmead should all have received a leaflet asking them to formally object to this development and to have the Green removed from Bexley's Development Plan. Please fill them in and send them to Bexley. For the price of a stamp everybody can make their views known and hopefully save this valuable green space for ever.

Anyone wanting a copy of the leaflet can 'phone Tim Chapman on 8310 5767.

WILDLIFE

Wildlife agencies continue to visit the Green and are compiling reports to support the preservation of this hugely important open space. They all support the fact that if proper wildlife surveys had been carried out whilst Bexley was formulating its Unitary Development Plan (UDP) and the animals that inhabit the Green had been discovered then, then the Green would not have been given its industrial designation.

REMOVED

Consequently, now that Bexley is reviewing the UDP, the Green should be removed from the UDP and given the legal protection it so desperately requires.

WORLD'S LUNGS

We all complain of the rain forest destruction around the world – they are the world's lungs. Yet here we are allowing the destruction of our small remnants of wild green spaces.

Thames-side marshlands are all under threat from uncaring developers who seem to think that communities only want factories, warehouses and overcrowded roads.

This community is not one of them. Please support your local community groups and help save Southmere Green for the future.

NEW

Gallions Housing Association and Trust Thamesmead jointly own Tilfen, so perhaps now is the time for both of them to take notice of the wishes of the community and get Tilfen to preserve Southmere Green in its present wildlife-rich state.

NOT NECESSARY

Tilfen owns huge swathes of land in Thamesmead that are now being developed, both for housing and for industry. It is not necessary to develop Southmere Green.

Residents of Thamesmead moved here from inner cities with the expectation and promise of room to breathe and to enjoy our green open spaces.

Why then is Tilfen trying to bring the inner city and its associated problems here? Gallions Housing and Trust Thamesmead please note.

INCINERATOR

The municipal waste incinerator planned for Belvedere was rejected by Bexley planners and now has to go to a public inquiry.

However, there is a large lobby within the Government that sees incineration as the only answer to Britain's waste disposal problems.

Sustainable recycling must now be given the opportunity to prove its worth. It can be done, as schemes in Holland and Germany prove. Incineration in those countries is now only used to dispose of what cannot be recycled.

The incinerator at Deptford has so many polluting incidents that Bexley has switched back to landfill.

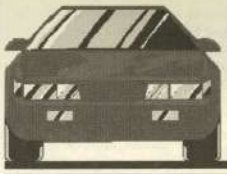
NOT GOOD

The Belvedere Incinerator plans to use the same technology as at Deptford. Not exactly a good thing for any of us.

Ed: research was published in the Guardian *last past week indicating a far higher level of toxicity in the dioxins released by* all *incinerators than was previously thought.*

That research coupled the influence of waste disposal (incinerator) companies with Government policy. Readers would do well to carry out their own research into dioxins at libraries and on the Internet.

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THE LEN COLE COLUMN

What a month! I've had a wonderful time. I met my grand-daughter's boy friend for the first time and to mark the occasion he arranged a trip in a helicopter! It was a first for me and a wonderful experience.

Then I had five days in France. I went with my old mate Arthur. It was his turn to pay.

Guess what? When we got on the *Seacat* at Folkestone he found he had brought £30 with him. No change there then! So, as usual, everything has been put on my Visa. What's a few quid to Midland Bank?

The food and wine were excellent. The weather was very good and only once did Arthur go round a roundabout the wrong way. After I told him that the French people prefer you to drive on the right whilst in their country we had no more trouble. We did a lot of driving and, to pass the time, he had brought two tapes with him.

The first he had bought from a busker in London. This consisted of songs from 1940s films, sung by an ageing Irishman. The second was an hour and a half of Swedish folk songs. I now have an idea of why Sweden has a high suicide rate.

I was pleased to discover that duty-free is still available and there seems to be no restriction on the amount you can have. I almost got a hernia carrying mine to the car. Perhaps that's what the health warning means.

Now about this time every year I have a birthday. I celebrated by going to the doctor with a breathing problem. He suggested I should give up smoking. Brilliant. Just when I'd bought a couple of dozen packs of rolling tobacco!

To help me stop smoking I have decided on a course of *Feng Shui*. That is the ancient Chinese art of putting the telly in the other corner.

Until next month, look after yourselves and good luck to you all.

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Challenge at The Moorings

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

The garden of the Arnott Close Community Hall in Thamesmead is the scene of a challenge to the local people on Monday, June 5, as part of National Volunteers Week

THE Greenwich Volunteers organisation, now with a base in the C2K Club in Eynsham Drive, Abbey Wood, is spearheading a concerted campaign that includes activities in Eltham, Woolwich, Greenwich and Thamesmead.

LOCAL

The local "roadshow" activities are in Woolwich Market on Thursday, June 1; the Safeway store in Thamesmead on Tuesday, June 6 and in the Woolwich Town Hall foyer from Thursday, June 1 to Wednesday, June 7.

A "Volunteering Quiz" is part of the roadshow, to test people's knowledge about volunteering, with a prize draw at the end of the week in the Town Hall, Woolwich.

The whole activity is being organised by a partnership between Greenwich Volunteer Co-ordinators' Forum, Greenwich Council, Oxleas Health Trust and Volunteers Greenwich. It is aimed to be a week-long programme of events and activities to celebrate volunteering and to promote the benefits to those who may have some time to give, but have never previously thought about becoming a volunteer.

FOUR CHALLENGES

Four "Volunteering Challenges" will take place in the two weeks prior to National Volunteers Week, each involving a group of employees from local organisations or enterprises.

EMPLOYERS

Employers backing the scheme recognise the benefits that volunteering can bring to their staff and, subsequently, to their organisations.

These include increased motivation; team building; development of social, leadership and communication skills as well as the opportunity to learn new skills.

So where does The Moorings come into all this? Well, surprise, surprise, they want to spread the word of volunteering around the neighbourhood of The Moorings.

IMPACT

And they intend (plans are still being finalised) to make a distinct impact on that day. Already, local businesses and organisations are getting involved, including the Metropolitan Police.

It will, of course, be yet another surprise if that young PC Rick Beavis turns up on the day!

So keep an eye open for the activities (they should be *very* evident) that day.

To give you a smell of the steak, volunteers are decorating a room used by mothers and toddlers and the after-school club at Henwick School Eltham; creating a children's play area at the Trinity Centre, Plumstead and helping to make a sensory garden at Age Concern House, Eltham.

FIND OUT!

So what are we going to see in The Moorings? Go and find out!



Rosie couldn't manage to do her column this month – she apologises, but she's been on an intensive course which you'll hear about next month.

PAWS FOR THOUGHT



Hi, it's us office canines again – hope you're enjoying our column.

Well here's the latest news. We've been busy as usual this month, our humans picked up a very bedraggled fox near our Centre. It had an infectious disease and was feeling very sorry for itself. It was collected by a wildlife rescue organisation and hopes are high that it can be treated and re-released.

We see a lot of wildlife around here (my human doesn't let me chase any!). Lots of the canines around here take their humans for a walk around the park and adjoining fields where there is an abundance of nature to be seen and enjoyed by all.

Our bunnies are hopping off all over the place. To new homes, that is, but we still have plenty of them who still need caring new homes.

I smell a rat about the place! Five, actually, recent residents and I suppose I have to admit they don't really smell. Quite decent, friendly chaps actually: Eeny, Meeney, Miney, Mo and Roland (naturally!).

MOTHERLY LOVE

Would we expect any mother to let her children learn to walk *through broken glass, tin cans and rubbish*? No, most definitely not, yet our wildlife have no choice. So please, take your rubbish home!

SLINKY

Well, we Adder get one eventually. Yup, the work slithered to a halt recently as our humans gathered to see "Slinky", our first snake resident (we canines were a little hssst off with all the attention he got!).

DECOR

Our personal artist is doing wonders here – do come and have a dekko at our new decor. Many thanks to local children who are raising money for us which they organised themselves, so don't tar all the youth of today with the same brush!

TOP THAT

Our humans have a reputation for attempting to rescue anything, but I take my hat off to them this month. Yes, you've guessed it, they rescued a hat! A lady came to us in desperation when her hat landed in Southmere Lake. It was a successful rescue – they managed to fish it out using a large net.

TIPS

Lots of humans keep hamsters. These delightful little pets are fairly easy to look after. In German the name hamster means hoarder, which describes this friendly fellow's favourite habit – hoarding.

Hamsters love to stuff their cheek pouches with food and then scurry off to hide their treasure trove for a rainy day.

It can be disconcerting for the first-time owner to see their pet's cheeks swell so much, indeed many 'phone their vet's, thinking that Hammy is seriously ill!

Golden hamsters were introduced into this country in 1938, as laboratory animals. Their debut as pets started around 1947. The first hamsters were of Syrian origin.

There are many colour mutations now, including the albino, piebald, amber, cinnamon and white-band.

Housing. Commercial hamster cages can be obtained from most pet shops. They are usually made of metal and are equipped with removable bottoms for easy cleaning. Always buy the largest cage you can afford. Hamsters are active animals that like to climb around.

The bottom of the cage should be lined with absorbent material, wood shavings or especially-prepared hamster litter. A cage equipped with an exercise wheel will give your pet hours of fun.

Hamsters should be kept in a room with a temperature between 55° and 70°f. A drop in temperature may cause them to go into a state of hibernation.

Feeding. A hamster's diet is basically simple – hard grains like wheat or corn, sunflower seeds and occasional fresh greens and fruit. Root vegetables like carrots are very good. Commercial hamster food is best as it contains all the vitamins and minerals they require. A tablespoonful a day should be adequate.

Hamsters are most active in the early evening. This is the best time to feed them. Fresh water must always be available. Again, water-bottles are easily bought from pet food outlets. Do not leave uneaten fresh food in the cage – it goes rotten very quickly and, if consumed by your pet, can cause intestinal problems. Hamsters should not be fed acid fruit such as oranges or grapefruit.

Health. Hamsters are susceptible to human colds and respiratory infections, so if anyone in the family has such an infection, keep him or her away from the cage.

VISIT

Listlessness, dull eyes, ruffled coat and no appetite indicate that all is not well and that a visit to your vet's is necessary.

Generally, hamsters are remarkably healthy animals, as long as their needs are catered for properly.

THANKS

Thanks to Helen and family from Holstein Way for donating cages and vitamins. Words cannot describe our gratitude. Helen, the cage was soon occupied by two guinea-pigs – it didn't remain empty for long! Also, many thanks to the lady who donated two bikes to us; to Steve, for a much-needed rotary clothesline and our thanks to those who helped with donations.

SYMPATHY

Our sympathy to the lady whose Jack Russell, when we took it to the vet's, had to be put to sleep, after it was attacked by two Staffordshire Bull Terrier Please can we ask that dogs be kept on leads if they are liable to fight – while staffies are generally wonderful with people it must be remembered that they were originally bred to fight, and this can be apparent in some stock.

MAKE A DATE

Our Dog Show is being held on June 25 this year (not June 26 as was said last month). Also, we are having another Open Day at the Rescue Centre. More details are available from the Rescue – 020 8311 5086. Well, that's all folk, see you at all your venues I hope. Best wishes from the office canines, Charles, Meg, Khya, Alice and Tod.





medical matters

BY DR P ANAND

DEALING WITH LOSS

I would guess that those reading this article have had to experience the death of someone they care about.

In doctor's terms, the word used to describe the process of someone dealing with loss is bereavement.

This process is different for all. There are similarities, but everyone goes through it in their own way. Grieving causes a host of emotions, resulting in sorrow and confusion.

How long the whole thing lasts depends on many factors, such as how close the attachment was and for how long, was the loss expected or unexpected, was it an accident or a suicide?

In England we are not, as a society, well prepared for death. I find this very sad, frustrating and amazing. Just as for having a baby and sex, the preparation of our children and almost everyone in our society for death is *totally inadequate*. We will all die. Most of us are involved in families. The skills and ideas involved need great care to be introduced to the young so that they are part of their coping skills from early life!

To have to go through this process of bereavement feels dreadful. The problem is that this is *normal*. Healthy, active, attachments mean that when someone dies, those close to them will miss them. This is "felt" in all sorts of ways.

Just after the death a feeling of numbness and shock sets in. This is actually a good thing as it gives the person a numb period to cope. There is sharing the news and all the arrangements to be achieved.

In the short to medium term, the loss sets in and this causes strong emotional responses to set in too – despair, fear, sadness, confusion, guilt, anger, hatred, blame and loneliness are common, as well as loss of focus and direction.

How will I cope? Who shall I turn to? How shall I cope on my own? They were so young? Why now? HELP!! Am I going *mad*? These emotions can overwhelm some people.

The reality leads to physical problems such as headache, poor sleep, restlessness, feeling sick, upset tummy, tiredness, loss of appetite, nightmares, loss of self-control and thought processes, sexual problems and emotions being very variable. All this goes on and is usually in relation to the emotional attachment to the lost person.

This part cannot be speeded-up to suit modern life's quick cure. Bereavement takes its own time! We can block out the emotions by distracting ourselves sometimes, but they must be allowed to come back so they can be allowed to evolve naturally. Over-interference only puts off the agonies.

Seeing or hearing the dead person is normal. Our brains need time and "invent" images to ease the loss.

A couple of people, called Bowlby and Parkes, and another called Worden, tried to explain loss: there is a *shock* and *numbness* at the beginning. Then comes *yearning* and *searching* with the acceptance of the reality of the loss, and working through and experiencing the physical and emotional pain of grief.

This is followed by *disorganisation* and *despair*, with a feeling of energy loss described as depression, and problems with looking to the future, concentrating and doing anything properly.

Finally there is *reorganisation*, with adjusting to a world without the lost one and transferring emotions and loyalties to the living, allowing life to go on and, indeed, to move forward!

Interference with any of these steps can seriously damage the bereavement process and cause an individual serious short and long term suffering and on-going problems.

As a doctor, I need to help people to accept the loss, understand their feelings and allow nature and natural processes to work in often very complicated personalities. I need to enable this and then move people on, from children to the very old, and at all stages allow them to function, cope and then reform and grow out of the experience, to take life as normally as possible.

This includes withdrawal of emotions from the dead, to allow new relationships to form, or old ones to strengthen, to enable a person to function as a new individual, with an ability to make independent decisions, recognise inappropriate grieving and leave it alone or recognise complicated or inappropriate, excessive, grieving and seek help or temporary use of short-term prescription drugs to manage this type of reaction and make individuals aware of forthcoming sensitive times, such as anniversaries, Christmas or birthdays.

Particular care is needed to deal with those who come to me after a recent (6–18 months) death, to complain of vague physical problems, as these may be due to the bereavement and must *not* be misinterpreted or missed.

Other presentations may be by no-grief reactions, feelings of ongoing panic or anger or guilt feelings, or excessive drug and/or alcohol use and also intense grief which goes on and on and does not seem to be resolving.

Reassurance is essential, and generally explaining what a *normal reaction* is like and the understanding of it is enough. Drugs are to be resisted! Having someone to *listen* carefully and sympathetically is an enormous help. One-to-one, on a private basis, is absolutely necessary, as a doctor, to help.

Sometimes, I even try to visit a family or bereaved person to see if I can help. One-to-one, on a private basis, is absolutely necessary, as a doctor, to help. It is rarely accepted as most people do come and talk to and talk to me in my room.

The loss or feelings can go with the bereaved for the rest of their lives. Help from GPs and counsellors also depends on the relationships established with their clients.

This is one of the hardest jobs I ever had to cope with. Personally, as I know most of my patients well, the whole process affects me very badly and I take time getting over each loss as it comes. Good luck to anyone reading this in a bereaved situation. My heart goes out to you.

Thamesmead conscience

This is a monthly column written by an individual not connected to the *People* or any other business. It is intended to provoke thought.

I have been looking this month at the level of service provided to personal customers of high street banks, in contrast to last month when I looked at the service to the small- and medium-sized businesses. I have to say, again, that I have been extremely disappointed by the efforts made by the banks to look after and support our local community.

There are generally three clearly defined types of customer at the banks these days.

The first category is of the wealthier customers with some savings, who own their own homes. These people are constantly bombarded with marketing calls about buying the banks' savings and investment products. To sell to this group of people is of course the most lucrative to the local branch and most of the marketing initiatives are directed to them.

More recently, the banks have targeted this group of people for other mortgage-related services such as further life cover or insurance, such as against critical illness – the banks' so-called current great selling product. It is good that these products are brought to people's attention, but the call is often disguised as a "service" call to check everything is alright, rather than telling you the real reason they are calling is to sell you a particular product.

This group of customers is a one which the banks would not wish to lose and so it receives more attention, as customers, than other groups.

The second category is, generally, the family groups or individuals with salaried incomes being paid into their accounts directly. This group is highlighted regularly for personal loans and other lending products such as credit cards, mortgages and health cover.

The banks have categorised this group as the most likely to buy their loan products and they have great marketing promotions to tempt people to over-commit their household budgets. It is a great misconception that when your bank sends you a letter saying they have reserved you a loan of several thousand pounds that any consideration has been given to whether or not you can afford to repay that amount.

It is unlikely that the banks have any idea what your outgoings are and, therefore, the loan is based on general factors about you and your credit score (credit score is your risk assessment built up as a score – therefore pass the score and they lend you money, without any real consideration of your circumstances).

This is the group most likely to need the support of their banks but, trust me, should your circumstances change for the worse, the bank will rush to restrict its support for you and will offer little support to help you through the difficult period.

The last category comprises those who have little, or who run on very tight budgetary restrictions. The banks do not market to this group because people in it have very low incomes and are, therefore, considered "high risk" to the banks. This group actually contains some of the best money managers around – operating on limited means is not an easy task.

This group receives no support from the banks and is often lucky to get basic facilities, such as cheque cards or credit cards. In this area of high poverty, the banks actually avoid this group of people. The banks will, however, provide students overdrafts, ranging from £750 to £1,500, even when they have no income – and actually encourage them to spend using credit cards.

In summary, the banks are there to sell their goods. They make noises about offering better service, but has anybody actually seen the services improve? Less cashiers and receptionists should be the first clue to the fact that high street banks are becoming a thing of the past. Customer contact is being replaced by call centres. Cash is being replaced by credit or switch cards and massive branch closures are money-saving measures that are killing local communities.

If, as reported in the local papers, the University of Greenwich moves out of Woolwich, I predict that bank closures in Woolwich will not be far behind. Where will you then go for your banking? Tell me what you think.

The Ribbon of exposure and criticism will be awarded each month in this column.

Your call is anonymous. It won't be recorded. It can't be traced. An experienced detective will answer you. Any cash reward can be picked up anonymously.

PUT A CROOK AWAY!

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Family fun

PRESS RELEASE

THIS year's Biggin Hill International Air Fair on June 3 and 4 will be celebrating a century of flight.

The most significant milestones in aviation history will be brought to life in a dynamic display, bringing together vintage aircraft with the sophisticated machinery that is ushering in the new millennium.

SPECTACLE

From the earliest machines to take to the air, through the development of combat aircraft, to flying for pleasure and the technical advances of the past 50 years, the show will provide a living spectacle of the achievements of the 20th century.

GROUND

And while the skies are crowded with more than six hours of aerial action each day, the entertainment on the ground will provide something for all the family with classic vehicles on display, a circus, funfair, craft stalls, collectors' centre and a host of other attractions and amusements.

BLERIOT

The living history programme will open with a tribute to the Pioneers of Flight and a visit from a *Bleriot XI*, the aircraft which carried Louis Bleriot into the history books in 1909 when he became the first man to fly a heavier-than-air machine across the English Channel.

WWI

Sticks and String will pay tribute to the intrepid airmen of World War I and their fragile machinery. Replica fighters will take to the skies, providing a sharp contrast to the hi-tech, modern warplanes.

As well as the show in the air, visitors will be able to enjoy an insight into wartime life with the recreation of a wartime encampment presented by the Great War Society, complete with "Tommies" explaining what life was like on the front.

FLUTTER-BY

In the 1920s and 30s flying became a leisure pastime and to celebrate the arrival of popular aviation, a large group of De Havilland *Moths* will be presenting a massed "flutter-by" before landing and offering crowds a close-up look at the machines that first made flying fun.

The Royal Air
Spitfire, Hurrica
Lancaster are am
legendary aircraft
feature in the W
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finest classic Ar
machinery fro
Fighter Collection
Breitling Fighters,
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powerful piston-dri
craft ever built, I
Tigercat, Bearcat,
and *Hellcat*.

DAKOTA

This year is the 6
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CLASSIC C

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Brooklands Colle

The Surrey Tr
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CIRCUS

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gate on the day.

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adults is £11 in a
or £14 on the da
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Ed: the Pe
sending a Thame
Community Colle
dent as its rep
watch for it next n

Churchfield celebrates

LBG

Churchfield Special School celebrated an excellent Ofsted report this month

THE School was congratulated on its strong and clear educational direction and was praised for its extra-curricular activities.

PROUD

George Gyte, Greenwich's director of education, said "I am extremely proud of our achievements here at Churchfields. We have a stable and very experienced team of teachers and this no doubt contributes to the overall success of the School.

"This experience shows particularly in the quality of the teaching, more than 99% of which was satisfactory or better. The Report commented on the children's strong sense of purpose which, I believe, provides a positive climate for learning."

GOOD SCHOOL

The Report describes Churchfield as a good school, saying its strengths far outweigh its weaknesses and says that the quality of the education provided at the School is good. The report confirms that Paul Goulden, headteacher, provides very clear educational direction and says that the quality of teaching has improved considerably since the previous report. A school representative is elected annually to the Greenwich Young People's Council.

Safeway ups the ante!

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

THE management of Thamesmead's Safeway store, recognising the success of the Safeway/*People* free competition, added to the *People*'s increased circulation in Abbey Wood, has from this month increased the prize to £100! So get in there, fill in your coupon and *win*! Safeway donates the vouchers (they can be spent on anything in the store) as part of their commitment to the community.



Michelle, from Thamesmead, left, this month's winner of the £50 Safeway/People free competition, collecting her condition-free £50 vouchers from Safeway's Kashmir. Now turn to the back page!

Easter bonnets at Safeway

PEOPLE EDITORIAL





THE very busy Creche at Safeway's Thamesmead store got the mums busy this Easter.

The Easter Bonnet Parade showed some wonderful feats of imagination – and not a little composure among the toddlers who had the unenviable task of wearing (and balancing) their mothers' creations!

AAAH

When they were shepherded by the watchful staff out into the coffee bar for a "public" display of their finery, with a few small, shy, tears, the "aaah" factor was high.

Not demanding of the young ones, the occasion was of course brightened for them by the "unexpected" decision to award them *all* big Easter egg prizes because the standard was so high.

Busy in the car park afterwards were families trying to get little 'uns, Easter eggs and bonnets into cars with the minimum damage. More Easter bonnets on page 10.







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Guess .....

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Address .....

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.....

Telephone number .....

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PROPRIETOR'S DECISIONS ARE FINAL

Winner announced in June's *Thamesmead People*

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10 TAVY BRIDGE

Trust Thamesmead seeks Independent Trustee

Trust Thamesmead is a registered charity which was formed in 1978 and has recently been restructured to deliver a new vision for its stakeholders.

Can you help to create a Trust that people believe in, to help them deliver their potential?

Your challenge will be in helping to achieve the Trust's objectives and core values which involve the relief of hardship, the assistance and advancement of less privileged persons, the creation and management of community projects and facilities. The Board is responsible for managing a £1m plus budget.

The Board is looking to appoint a person with a range of skills and experience including:

- Strategic Management and Planning
- Interpreting and understanding management accounts
- Legal responsibilities and liabilities that the Trust may face
- Experience in business management

The appointment will promote equality of opportunity and, where possible, reflect the make-up of the local community and, in particular, the black and ethnic community.

The appointment will be for a period of three years initially and the time commitment is approximately one to two days a month. Applications for this non-executive unpaid appointment should be sent to Miss Susan Bell, Company Secretary, Trust Thamesmead, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH by Monday, 19 June.

Further information is available from Sue Bell on 020 8320 3417, e-mail subell@thamesmead.co.uk or ring Julian Martin, Chief Executive, on 020 8320 3420.

Trust Thamesmead Ltd



"The birth of the new Trust Thamesmead is an exciting development. Under its banner we have a team of talented people committed to seeing this town succeed as a community. The past few months have involved us in many meetings and some searching debate. Now we are ready for action.

"The Trust will work to help local groups meet their goals. We also aim to provide plenty of activities for both the young and elderly. The Trust is also committed to helping unemployed residents obtain the training and skills necessary to get a job. But most of all Trust Thamesmead is about you, our residents. So come and see how we can help you."

Julian Martin, chief executive

THE TEAM ...



RESPONSIBILITIES

EMPLOYMENT INITIATIVE

Janice Piotrowski and Sharron Feetham – call Janice on 020 8320 3463 or Sharron on 020 8320 3465

ROVING STREET SCHEME

Trevor Cross (aka "Baldie") – for more details call Trevor on 020 8311 3453, mobile 0467 613 273.
Want to find out more about the Youth Forum? For more details, call Grant Land 07775 506 263

COMMUNITY INVOLVEMENT TEAM

Mary Chambers 020 8312 1101 – Nick Riley and Giles Randall 020 8320 3461 or mobile 07930 550 753

We're here for you – call us!

This year, for the community of Abbey Wood and Thamesmead:

MILLENNIUM FESTIVAL

The Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Millennium Festival – a once-in-a-lifetime experience bringing Thamesmead to life in the Year 2000. It's happening in Birchmere Park on September 16.

Carnival parade followed by an all-day Festival in the Park. Music, fun, children's activities and sport, area events, audience participation, side shows, fun fair and a host of new attractions.

If you would like to take part, to promote your organisation, or need more information, contact Mary Chambers – Community Support Officer on 020 8311 4470, or Nick Riley, or Giles Randall on (mobile) 07930 550 753

Trust Thamesmead – 020 8320 3461

Harrow Manor Way, Thamesmead SE2 9XH

Fancy a FREE night out? Meet the Stars?

If you would like *FREE* tickets to TV recordings, please leave you name, age and telephone numbe with Julie Scott o **8320 3461**

We will contact you with times and date (transport provided) shows to include *Pep Chart Show, C.D.U.K Barrymore, Gloria Hunniford*

For further info conta Grant Land, c/o Trus Thamesmead and Abbey Wood Youth Forum **0777 5506263**

The Roving Street Scheme presents Thamesmead Central Netball Club FOR WOMEN ONLY

Netball coaching eve Tuesday at Woolwic Polytechnic School, Waterfield Close, of Bentham Road, Thamesmead

FREE

Beginners' sessions (from 12 years up), 6 7.30pm; Seniors/Clu session 7.30-9.30pm

More info? Call o **8311 3453** or **8855 1601**

fun day

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Wednesday, May 31

10am to 3.30pm

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WE'RE RIGHT BY ABBEY WOOD RAIL STATION!

What with all the alarums and excursions taking place in the town this past month, visiting hostelries has been rare – a dry month, even allowing for the weather!

I couldn't even manage to go visit Debbie and Peter at the **Jolly Marshman** and Jim and Debbie at the **Belfry Club** – a trip down Plumstead way I'd been looking forward to. Ah well, June, perhaps.

I had a couple of meetings in the **Birchwood** in Abbey Wood though. Business, of course! The meetings just happened to be at lunchtimes, so I could get stuck into Jane's sandwiches. A rare sight there – a guy I was lunching with actually ordered, and ate, *two* sandwiches – hot, cooked, bacon and something! Unbelievable!

You live and learn.

But we did manage a couple of visits to the **Lakeside**, which really is developing as we'd all hoped – it's a grand place now, that's quiet enough to have a chat and friendly enough to be livened by laughter. The pool game is being well looked after there, with excellent facilities for young people.

We were told that darts is getting organised there too. But altogether, the walk round the lake is even more worthwhile now.

The **Cutty Sark**'s humming well – the business lunches are getting busy. Well, the toasted sandwiches I'm allowed are delectable!

An old name comes into prominence again. Do you recall the Royal Arsenal pub in Arnott Close that the druggies closed?

The latest talk is that a community organisation is trying to take it over to put the place back into use, perhaps just a bit more profitably this time. We'll keep you informed as things develop.

The entertainment at the **Dashwood Club** is pulling in the younger parts of the community, noisily, of course, but that's what they like it seems, and they've got to be provided for. Tony Cusack's direction of the place is very evident.

We haven't even had the time to visit the **Bargepole** pub and regulars keep asking when they'll see me in there again. Soon, honestly, I'll get there, Damien, really!

We should soon hear more details of the developments at Broadwaters, or the Royal Arsenal Park down there, because there's an entertainment complex planned and it will be right on the doorsteps for Broadwaters people – and about time too, eh?

We've come across some grumps recently – people who can't (or won't) talk to the landlords and think that by writing to me they'll cure their problems.

Haven't they learned the lesson my father taught me years ago – golden rule: you never, ever argue with the landlord. They're all quite reasonable people and after all, they all, round here, keep the pubs and clubs drug-free. That's no small thing and we should appreciate how hard that is.

Anyway, if you argue, who wins? You don't – you just get a bit dryer!

ACCESS

Rosie White, of WHAP (you see her column in the *People* most months) is disabled. She's also a doughty fighter for the disabled, if you hadn't noticed. She's commented to me about access for wheelchairs and it's a pity more public buildings don't follow the examples set by our landlords.

I think we'll hear more from her on that, as she's getting about the area more now and is likely to make quite a song and dance about the issue.

Now what about off-licences? When are they going to think about the clearing-up others have to carry out once they've sold crisps and bottled beer *etc* to their customers? What about biting the bullet and accepting that their customers need to be told not to use the streets and paths as their rubbish dumps?

I just think someone has to attempt to stem the tide of broken glass that endangers our children and animals every day, all around the town.

WELL?

Well what do *People* readers think about it? Are there any suggestions to ease this real problem? Let's hear them because you know I'll print them.

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GOOD BEER – RIGHT PRICE
CLUB MEMBERSHIP – PUB SPORTS
CHILDREN WELCOME

JUMBO TELLY FOR ALL THE SPORTS

WE CATER FOR FUNCTIONS TOO – SEE PAGE 15



At the Abbeymead Social Club










On Sunday, April 23 where every child had an Easter Egg



The Safeway check-out ladies






On Monday, April 24 where every customer got a "Happy Easter!"



GHA: town's new dream

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1



Mary Kemp, Rita Edney, and Joyce Couchman



Mike Matthews and Andrew Thompson



Ray Hill and Roy Nixon



Keith Robinson and Tony Cotter



Peter Lapper and Tracey Mahey



George Gardiner



Cllr Peter Brookes



Graham Horton and Ken Sealey



Cllr John Fahy, Brian Knowler and Irene Howe



Keith Robinson, Julian Martin and Cllr Mike French



Cllr Peter Brookes, Cllr Peter Kotz and Dave Scott



Linda Nash, Mike Matthews, Tony Cox and Tom Nash

AT noon on Friday, April 28, the formal Transfer of Business from Thamesmead Town Ltd to Gallions Housing Association was successfully completed. Gallions is now an independent housing association.

Last July 84% of residents voted for change and a new way forward for Thamesmead.

Gallions Housing Association is a not-for-profit charitable landlord and will now take over the running of the housing service for the Thamesmead area. The Board includes residents, representatives from the boroughs of Bexley and Greenwich and independent board members.

DELIVERING PROMISES

John Fahy, chair of the Association is "looking forward to delivering on the promises made to our residents. Our aim is to work closely with our residents to ensure they continue to help set the agenda. We are also in the process of registration with the Housing Corporation as a Registered Social Landlord and are hopeful this will be achieved in June".

Over the last few months significant progress has been made in preparing the organisation to take on its responsibilities as an independent housing association and the Board of Gallions is committed to high quality services, delivered efficiently, whilst having regard for the needs of the community.

PARTNERSHIP

Finally, chief executive of Gallions Housing Association Tony Cotter said "We can now look confidently forward to the challenges that lie ahead. Much has already been achieved, but much more remains to be done. We will work in partnership with others to secure benefits, which will make the difference for all residents."

GHA approached a firm of design consultants to oversee a logotype design competition for the enw housing association. Students from years seven, eight and nine, from both Woolwich Polytechnic College and Thamesmead Community College were asked for ideas.

The standard was very high and the building block approach, from Pardeep Marwaha, was chosen.

So now the road is signposted. The future of the GHA will involve the residents as never before. Now, they must get involved – they *did* win.





Top, Woolwich Polytechnic College student Pardeep Marwaha and, above, Thamesmead Community College students Helena Saldanha and Jenny Diep receiving the cheques for their creativity

CONTRIBUTIONS FROM THE VOLUNTEERS IN THE ESTATE MANAGEMENT BOARDS OF THE GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Estate Management Board 1

COVERING BROADWATERS, WATERFIELD AND MOORINGS

Board members: Anthony Cox, Terry Greaves, Tom Nash, Don Tidey, Robin Chapman, Ray Hill, Olive Williams, Daniel Breach, Frank Flood, Irene Howe, Brian Knowler, Meg Cherney, Pauline Robinson, Patricia Wallington

EMB projects in hand: Notice boards/fitting; Circular brick barriers; Temple Close, bollards; Lakeside, bollards/markings; Cross/Mill/Besant/Mann, parking; Galsworthy/Waterfield, rails/bollards; Cole Close, bollards; Titmus/Besant, rails/path; Mill/Cross/Besant, bollards; Manning/Chadwick, parking; Blocking HWH bays; Signage to area; Disraeli, chicane; Wren/Pigeon, security grills; Malthus Path, brick construction; Malthus/Owen, dished area and Galsworthy Close/Dean, bollards.

Estate Management Board 2

COVERING CROSSWAY, GREENMEAD, MANORWAY AND SOUTHMERE

Board members: Sam Robinson, R Edney, O Ademoyero, Ray Woodage, David Warsaw, Carol Hardiman, David Scott, Michael Matthews, Jan Topping, Fred Orford, Raphael McHale, Thelma Jackman

EMB projects in hand: Aspen Green, overhead bus stop lighting; Whimbrel Close, light for flats; Fieldfare Road, additional street lighting; Goldcrest Road, motorcycle barrier modifications; Parkway and Alsike Road, additional paving by bus stop; Southmere Lake by Tavy Bridge, railings to waterside; Fieldfare Road, two park benches; Manorway Green, Millennium Park.

Estate Management Board 3

COVERING LESNES AND PARKVIEW

Board members: Keeley Savill, Valerie Killman, Louis Churchman, Joyce Couchman, Elizabeth Gardiner, George Gardiner, Graham Horton, Mary Kemp, Ian Nicholas, Roy Nixon, Pauline Oates, Kenneth Sealey, Sandy Wood

EMB projects in hand: Coralline Walk, Mangold Way, property front enclosures; Kale Road (Timothy House), garage improvements; Limestone Walk; murals, street lighting, landscaping; Maran Way, parking bays, enclose garage areas, with lockable gate and wall, Kale Road (John Fisher), pathway paving, picnic benches; Wolvercote Road, bus stop improvements, Radley House play area, improved fencing, murals, etc. **New:** Coralline Walk, grassed play/dog-free; Lensbury Way, improve parking and notice boards to all high-rise lobbies.

Tenants' and Residents' Associations make life better!



"Gallions Housing Association is committed to tenant and resident (charge-payers) involvement in the running of the housing service. There are three Estate Management Boards (EMBs) currently running in Thamesmead. Each board is made up of 15 tenants and charge-payers living in Thamesmead and is chaired by an elected tenant," says Linda Nash, Gallion's Tenant Participation Officer. "Tenants' and Residents' associations are an essential part of the implementation of that policy – *you* can be involved in *your* future."



"As a member of a tenants' or residents' association you would have an input into helping the EMBs allocate their budgets. These are for environmental improvements. They could be improved lighting, extra cleaning to communal areas, or minor security improvements. Wherever you have a problem the EMBs will try to resolve it but, more than that, you will be involved in looking at the best solution – making sure it's right first time. The EMBs' budgets are limited, so you may not get what you want first time, but all ideas will be looked into."

"As more tenant's and residents' associations start to form – we've got seven starting the process already – you'll find that you will have a greater say in what happens to your home and area."

"So get involved! contact me on 020 8320 3451."

I am a member of EMB 3 and I would like to tell you a little of what we are trying to do to help make Thamesmead a better place in which to live.

Amongst things like parking bays, lighting and children's play areas we have already tackled, we've many other projects in the pipeline.

We also visit other housing associations to learn how they manage their housing estates – I'd like to tell you of such a visit to Oxford Citizens' HA, on April 6. We left Thamesmead at 9.15, arriving at Oxford around 12 noon after a pleasant journey.

On arrival we were made most welcome by the OCHA committee, who shared knowledge and experience of how they purchased the land and, from nothing, came to being the fine estate it is today. How they tackled vandalism and graffiti and all the other problems that come with running an estate – though they are a lot smaller than Thamesmead we have a lot in common in that respect.

We came away, after a pleasant day, with a number of things, ideas and plenty to think about for our future.

Thamesmead is a fine town and we want the best for us all – journeys like that to Oxford help.

So if you have any ideas on what you would like to see changed or improved, give us your ideas, which we will try to pursue. So get involved, it's your town as well as ours!

J Couchman

WELL?
Further improvements can only be funded if money doesn't have to be spent on vandalism and graffiti. Example: in the last 12 weeks £12,000 has been spent clearing graffiti and £10,000 repairing vandalism damage. So what do you think?

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Harrow Manor Way
Thamesmead, London SE2 9XH
Tel: 020 8310 1500
Fax: 020 8310 1811

Chair Cllr John Fahy
Chief executive Tony Cotter

Contact board members through the Resource Centre in Harrow Manor Way (the old "cinema"), in person or on 020 8320 3451

THE ABOVE SPACE, TO APPEAR MONTHLY, IS FREELY PROVIDED BY THE *THAMESMEAD PEOPLE* TO THE EMB MEMBERS OF GALLIONS HA TO FACILITATE THEIR COMMUNICATION WITH RESIDENTS



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Gallions HA defends record

PRESS RELEASE

FOLLOWING Thamesmead's hand-over of administration from TTL to Gallions Housing Association, Bexley Council has turned down a request to take over the maintenance of Crossway and Southmere open spaces.

SHOWCASE

Bexley claims these unfenced open spaces are less well maintained than its Borough showcase, Danson Park, and would cost too much to maintain in spite of the offer of a one-off payment from Gallions HA of £150,000.

Gallions is perplexed by Bexley's refusal. The Council has made no contribution for capital and revenue maintenance during the 13 years the open spaces have been under TTL's care. This means, effectively, that Thamesmead residents have been subjected to double tax for the parks' upkeep: firstly, through the Thamesmead service charge and, secondly, through the Council Tax paid to Bexley Council. Bexley has never considered offering residents a rebate in respect of this amount.

SURCHARGE

By Bexley's own admission, these open spaces cost £300,000 a year to maintain – a figure approaching a £1,000 surcharge on the Council Tax to each home in Thamesmead over the 13-year period.

RESPONSE

In response to Bexley's accusation of poor upkeep, TTL asserts it has always been careful to maintain these open spaces within the financial limits of what residents could afford.

The water in Southmere Lake complies with strict EU bathing standards even though it is fed from the Wickham Valley Culvert. This runs through neighbouring boroughs (including Bexley and Greenwich) picking up polluted discharges from illegal wc connections.

FINEST FISHING

Even so, the Environment Agency credit's Thamesmead's watercourses and lakes with having some of the finest coarse fishing in the South East of England – and that includes Southmere Lake. Fish to be found there include the largest non-trout water pike, 45lb carp, 14lb tench, 14lb bream with roach and crucian carp as well as large terrapins.

PROFIT

Bexley also implies that Gallions is holding on to profitable open spaces, such as the Riverside Golf Club. The Club is, in fact, owned by Tilfen Ltd, which leases to an independent operator. The Company receives no revenue or profit from the Club's membership and green fees or bar charges.

Gallions Housing Association firmly believes that Thamesmead's open spaces provide superb, green facilities for the enjoyment of children and adults throughout the Borough [*Ed: we can all witness to that!*].

Greenwich welcomes link

LBG

GREENWICH Council has given whole-hearted support to proposals to extend the Docklands Light Railway to the London City Airport. The plan also provides the opportunity for a further extension under the Thames to Woolwich, which the Council also fully supports.

IMPROVEMENT

The proposed extension to London City Airport, if extended to Woolwich, would mark a further step forward in the improvement of transport links for South East London, following the opening last year of the DLR Lewisham extension and the Jubilee Line extension.

EASIER REACH

Council leader and newly-elected London Assembly member Len Duvall said "The Council has long supported the idea of a rail crossing at Woolwich, because of the job opportunities that would be brought within easier reach of local residents.

"A link would also be a tremendous boost to the new leisure and heritage schemes being developed at the Royal Arsenal site ... also helping to reduce car use in the capital."

£30m at Royal Arsenal

LBG

A £30m proposal for a leisure scheme at the Royal Arsenal site has been made by Morrison Developments, to include a multiplex cinema, hotel, health and fitness club, nursery and recreational facilities, ten-pin bowling alley, retail sites and restaurants with a range of bars and family pubs.

Construction could begin in late Summer this year, ending in 2001.

Want the whole picture, honestly?
It's in the *Thamesmead People*

ALAN IVES

TALKS ON PROPERTY

This month I would like to send out a reminder to parents of children of school age. I have found that one of the main reasons people move is to be nearer to a suitable school for their children. The best time to move a child between schools is at the beginning of of the academic year in August.

In general, it takes three to four months to move, but each year I see people in July and August who want to be moved in time for September – but they run out of time and get disappointed.

So if you want to move for the start of the school year, get your skates on now! If you already own a house, the first step you need to take is to arrange for a free valuation of your present home.

So if you are in this position, don't delay, give me a call now on 020 8854 0101 and we can arrange a valuation without obligation.

Future Bexley Metropolitan Police Sector Working Party meeting dates (8pm in Erith Town Hall) are Monday, July 10 and Monday, October 9

EVENTS



Visit the Crossness Engines

MUSEUM OF SANITATION ENGINEERING

The world's largest rotative beam engines

at Thames Water's Crossness Works, Belvedere Road, Thamesmead SE2

Light Refreshments – Museum Shop – Large Free Car Park

Admission: Adults £3, children under sixteen and Trust members free. All visits are guided and start at 1.45pm

FLAT SHOES ARE ESSENTIAL – WHEELCHAIR ACCESS – CHILDREN UNDER 16 MUST BE ACCOMPANIED BY AN ADULT – VISITS MUST BE BOOKED IN ADVANCE

DATES FOR 2000

Tuesday, June 6 and Sunday, June 18
Tuesday, July 18 and Sunday, July 30
Tuesday, August 15 and Sunday, August 27
Tuesday, September 5
Tuesday, October 10 and Sunday, October 22
Tuesday, November 7 and Sunday, November 19
Tuesday, December 5

OPEN DAYS (no booking required)
Saturday, July 8 and
Sunday, September 24

THE CROSSNESS ENGINES TRUST
Telephone **020 8311 3711** any Tuesday or Sunday between 9 and 4

THE VILLAGE HALL BROADWATERS

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Broadwaters Management Committee

The AGM will take place on Monday, July 24 at 7.30pm in the Village Hall

ALL ARE WELCOME

four legged friends

ANIMAL RESCUE CENTRE
SOUTHMERE PARK
THAMESMEAD

DOG SHOW

SUNDAY, JUNE 25

Details from 020 8311 5086

Bexley in Bloom Competition

Details of this year's Bexley in Bloom Competition are available. If you would like further information about this free-to-enter gardening competition, or an entry form, please contact Jean Smith at **Bexley in Bloom, 40 Welling High Street, Welling, Kent DA16 1TQ** or telephone **020 8301 9206.**

GREENWICH +DOCKLANDS FESTIVALS

THE GREENWICH+DOCKLANDS FESTIVALS
JUNE 30 TO JULY 9, 2000

A riverfront spectacular of New World Music and Dance

FINE ARTS TO FIREWORKS
INTERNATIONAL AND INTERCULTURAL
FOR OLD 'UNS TO YOUNG 'UNS
DRUMMING TO DANCING

www.festival.org

TICKETS 020 8858 7755
INFORMATION ONLY 01865 777633

This Summer's exciting, free community festival

Carnival 365

has begun recruiting staff and planning stalls

Carnival 365 takes place at Eltham Green School on Sunday, June 25, from 12 noon to 6pm.

It will launch the tenth anti-racist week with
• • • • the theme of Unity 2000 • • • •

With live performances, sports events and taster sessions, with youth activities, arts and crafts, a children's parade, refreshments, food, together with arts and social issues workshops – there will be something there for all!

To make sure everyone gets the chance to take part, a sports worker will be responsible for getting young people and other targeted groups involved. A festival production manager is also being recruited to manage events.

Organisations wishing to have a stall should call projecct development officer Julie Timbrell, telephone 020 8856 8430, fax 020 8856 4434.

Festival organisers are Charlton Athletic Race Equality (CARE). Carnival 365 is organised by CARE in partnership with Greenwich Council, Charlton Athletic FC, Charlton Athletic Supporters' Club, GCRE, University of Greenwich, Woolwich College, Metropolitan Police, Greenwich Development Agency and ethnic minority groups and is supported by the South Greenwich Regeneration Agency



CHARLTON HOUSE
CHARLTON ROAD, CHARLTON SE7 8RE
020 8856 3951

HORN FAIR 2000
SUNDAY, JUNE 25
A family entertainment day

Applications for stalls at this annual event are now invited from recognised charity and community organisations

Nature Near

an exhibition of parks, gardens and green spaces in Greenwich, is running at Greenwich Borough Museum until the end of July

232 Plumstead High Street, SE10

Monday, 2–7pm; Thursday, Friday and Saturday 10am–1pm and 2–5pm – closed on Wednesdays, Sundays and bank holidays

Funded by Time to Celebrate and the New Millennium Experience Company

CROSSWAYS GYMNASTICS CLUB

MILLENNIUM 2000 DISPLAY EVENING

Wednesday, June 21 at 7.30pm

at Crossways Gymnastics Club, Byron Close, Thamesmead, SE28

Telephone 020 8312 1190

light refreshments

Due to limited space could you please telephone the above number and let us know how many people will be attending and if any are in wheelchairs, thank you.

THE ERITH RIVERSIDE FESTIVAL

Sunday, June 4
10 am to 5pm

A family fun day out by the river

10am blessing and opening ceremony
10.15am stalls and sidesshows open to public
pony sleigh rides
boat trips
11am indian dancing
chairton athletic goal scoring competition
11.30am riverside reflections baton twirlers
12 noon duncan doughnut children's entertainer
the churches together
12.30pm europa gymnastic display
1pm dincan doughnut children's entertainer
1.30pm atc marching drum band
2pm cajan big band
2.45pm celebration praise
3.15 festival free programme draw
3.45pm tog o'war
5pm close

ALSO

SHRIMPERS RACING
LASER GAME
CHILDREN'S RIDES
YACHT RACING
BOUNCY CASTLE

Greenwich Patients' Forums

Eltham Patients' Forum
Thursday, June 1
Passey Place Clinic, Eltham, SE9, 7–9pm

Arsenal Patients' Forum
Tuesday, July 4
Community Centre, Raglan Road, Plumstead SE18, 7–9pm

Meridian Patients' Forum
Tuesday, July 18, 7.15–9.15pm
The Forum@Greenwich, Trafalgar Road, Greenwich SE10

Multicultural Family Sports Day

(organised by the Voice of Mauritius charity)

A free family open-to-all sports day on SUNDAY, JUNE 4

at Sutcliffe Park Athletic Track, Eltham Road, SE9, from 12 noon

Events for entrants from 2 years to adults
Trophies and prizes – disabled participants and visitors welcome – food, bouncy castle, children's rides face-painting and music

Part of LB Greenwich's "Time to Celebrate" programme funded by Greenwich and the New Millennium Experience Company

BEXLEY MUSEUMS SERVICE

HALF-TERM CHILDREN'S WORKSHOPS

Are you aged between 6 and 11? Want to get out and do something different? Then why don't you come along to an active workshop at Hall Place?

On Thursday, June 1, at 10am to 12 noon, repeated from 2–4pm, we will be making optical illusions, inspired by real Victorian toys.

Tickets cost £3 per child, including refreshments

Come along and help us celebrate Museums and Galleries Month 2000! Tickets are available from Hill Place, Bourne Road, Bexley, Kent, telephone 01322 526574

GREENWICH PUBLIC SERVICES

Adult Lecture Series

The Royal Arsenal Woolwich

A talk by Alan Turner

Saturday, June 24, 2.30–4pm

at Greenwich Borough Museum
(first floor, Plumstead Library)
232 Plumstead High Street
London SE18 1JT

Limited places – for free places 'phone 8855 3240

Respond + Met = success

PRESS RELEASE



We were told the caption for this was "It's nice when a plan comes together", but it looks a bit complicated, doesn't it? These digital photographs were taken and supplied by the team

THE combined resources of Respond (Thamesmead) Ltd and the Thamesmead Police joined together on Wednesday, April 19, to organise a Team Building Day for the Prince's Trust Volunteers' Cray team.

Not altogether surprisingly, the event was organised by those two retiring characters Gary Redding, project manager at Respond and PC Rick Beavis from the Thamesmead part of the Metropolitan Police Service – working with Dawn Fox, the Prince's Trust's Cray leader.

The day comprised team building games, aimed at bringing individuals together to achieve an overall objective – forming part of the Prince's Trust objective of working with young people.

Gary told the *People* "It all went very well and the young people definitely got something out of it."

Well done to everybody, it looks like they had fun.





Top picture: working as a team to achieve set tasks and, bottom, getting to grips with tent building

Dragon Awards 2000

PRESS RELEASE

THE Lord Mayor of London, Alderman Clive Martin, challenges businesses in the City of London and London boroughs to become further involved in the campaign to revitalise inner-city communities and to put forward their projects for official recognition.

THIRTEENTH

Now in their thirteenth year, the awards are presented by the Corporation of London and supported by Business in the Community, and will be given in the following categories: Education and lifelong learning; Employees in the community; Community regeneration; The London partnership; City firm and Small to medium sized business.

CLOSING DATE

All projects undertaken by businesses in the City of London and London boroughs are eligible. The closing date for entries is Monday, July 3.

EDDIE GEORGE

Judges will include the Governor of The Bank of England Eddie George and BBC broadcaster and journalist Martyn Lewis.

To launch the Dragon Awards 2000 the Lord Mayor of London visited two outstanding examples of corporate community investment initiatives in East London and hosted a Mansion House reception for business leaders, politicians and representatives from agencies concerned with many of London's key community issues such as education, environment, homelessness, drugs and unemployment.

SHARE

The Lord Mayor of London said "Throughout London there are businesses running inspirational programmes with inspirational individuals keen to share their experience and time and these are the programmes that should be entering this year's award."

TELEVISED

Companies shortlisted will be invited to the televised awards ceremony at the Mansion House in October.

Marlborough Court awards

PEOPLE EDITORIAL



Faith, Sharon and Catherine with their NVQ Level II certificates presented by Malcolm Whitehead of Margaret Bardsley Management and Training Ltd

On a bright morning in April, those responsible for staff training at Thamesmead's Marlborough Court Care Centre staged an awards presentation

INTENDED to recognise the achievement of Faith, Sharon and Catherine in achieving their NVQ Level II certification and to present bonuses to six additional members of staff for outstanding performances, Rosemary Devaux ensured it was a day to remember for them.

With visitors and residents getting involved and a well-chosen buffet, it was a friendly occasion.

NO WAY

Not to be missed out was old *People* mate, resident George Corbyn (below). *There was no way he wasn't having his picture* taken! His family live in Thamesmead and visit him often.

Well done, Rosemary and your staff. As usual, Marlborough Court made it an enjoyable visit.



Resident Winnie Cumber, settled into her window armchair, ready for the buffet



General manager Rosemary Devaux and regional manager Margaret Kingston relaxing after the event



Left: local man George Corbyn enjoying the occasion with Rosemary, as is, right, John with Karen!

May for GAFC

The Club is looking forward to its annual Presentation Evening on May 27, to be held at the Birchwood pub.

The Club's sponsor, Europa Worldwide Services, has six awards to be won by the U15 players. These are: Player of the Year; Players' Player; Parents' Player; Most Consistent Player; Chairman's Award; Axiom Most Sporting Award as well as seven Europa Player of the Month Awards. There are also four players due to pick up 100 League Appearance trophies.

The season has been pretty OK, the high points being doing the double over Hayden and the trip to tour Wembley Stadium, which was a good day out.

The lows were losing striker Steven Nicola with a broken arm and losing in the first round of the Bexley and London Cup competitions.

We have to accept that only one team can win the League out of 12 teams. We've never finished out of the top four in all the years of the Bexley League, but with the four new lads joining next season I'm pretty confident of some long overdue success. We are looking forward to the five tournaments entered this Summer. We've been pretty successful in the 5-a-sides recently, reaching no less than six finals and winning three.

We are off to Margate on June 3 for a Lads and Dads day out. If the weather is good we'll have a brilliant day.

We also played our Lads and Dads match recently. Last year the boys thrashed us 8–1, so we were looking for revenge.

After ten minutes we were 2–0 down, after Adam Craig and Dan Bebbington scored for the U15s. The Dads were still in with a shout, but Neil Sugden and ex-assistant manager Tony Day, out of retirement for the day, missed sitter after sitter.

Neil hit the woodwork twice and Tony headed against the bar and blasted a volley over the top from six yards!

The Lads punished us when Darren O'Laughlin made it 3–0 and David O'Dwyer 4–0.

Guest Michael Nicola pulled one back before Allen Gobbett "shinned" the fifth.

I scored from the penalty spot to make it 5–2 to the Lads. Maybe next year!

Speak to you next month, 'bye for now, *Wayne Baldacchino.*

The Moorings Club FC!

PEOPLE EDITORIAL





Birchmere Park's wildlife ...



The Moorings Club, the well-known Thamesmead social centre, has football prowess too – above, the referee Jean, the teams in action and the well-lubricated supporters ...

ON that Saturday when we had our Summer (remember it, April 29?) the *People* was called out to see the lads from the Moorings Club, Thamesmead, in their soccer guise. Birchmere Park was hot and sunny – the players were hot too. As to sunny – well ...

Spectating supporters (many fresh from a little drinkie at the Moorings) were vocal in their comments – but we won't repeat them here.

The point of the day's endeavours was to raise money for the teams' kits. No sponsors exist for them at the moment (note well, local businesses!) so they have to do it the time-honoured Thamesmead way – DIY!

£400!

They raised, surprisingly, £400! Now that's a real achievement. Well done everybody, especially the organisers and wives and girl-friends who've enabled it all.

These lads play for fun, but they're serious enough about it for AFC Moorings to play in the London & Kent Border League. They may not have won many matches, but their commitment is "fabulous", says manager Steve Walker.

"It's the first season for them," says Steve, "and I think they're doing great. Who knows, with their commitment – and you should see them training – *anything*'s possible."





The AFC Moorings team members top and, above, the Gunns Transport All-Stars team members. AFC Moorings thank Gunns All-Stars for taking part in this very enjoyable event – helping make it a success

Winning ways ...

LBG

GREENWICH Council's Sports Development team scooped half of this year's FA regional women's football awards.

They were: the Local Authority Scheme, received by Steve Johnston (leading officer of the sports development team); Sportscoach of the Year award, won by Claire Shevlin, and the Outstanding Contributor award, won by Josie Clifford for her terrific input into girls' football.

POPULAR

Women's football has become immensely popular since its first kick-off in Greenwich, over two years ago. There are borough representative teams, schools competitions, champion coaching schemes, even a football festival for girls – which this year will be held on June 22 at the London Marathon Playing Fields, Shooters Hill.

The Greenwich Sports Development Unit has formed partnerships with Charlton Athletic Football Club, McDonalds, Greenwich Leisure Ltd, the Football Association, the London Football Association, local schools and youth centres, Charlton Athletic's Race and Equality Unit and local clubs.

You see something? Sort it ...

CRIMESTOPPERS

0800 555 111

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FAIRWAY DRIVE, OFF SUMNERTON ROAD, THAMESMEAD

PREMIERSHIP FOOTBALL LIVE ON SKY

DRIVING RANGE SPECIAL OFFERS

Tuesday and Thursday evenings, 6 to 8pm

£1 FOR 50 BALLS

SENIOR CITIZENS' OFFER

Tuesdays and Thursdays 10am to 12 noon

£1 FOR 50 BALLS

Course, Restaurant and Bars open to the public

Telephone 020 8310 7975

Determination

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

OUR Glenn Powell, local marathon runner, busy dad and karate enthusiast, really showed his determination when he ran in the London marathon on April 16.

He'd already run the Paddock Wood half-marathon on March 26, then the Docklands half-marathon on April 2, so he'd already taken some punishment.

SHOULD

He'd consulted a doctor before the London marathon and received laser treatment for troublesome ligaments. He'd been told the legs "should" last out.

After seven miles, the knees gave up! He received assistance, "Oh, bless the St John's people!" he says, and they strapped up his knees so well that he could only walk stiff-legged.

And on he went! Struggling to walk as he was, he *finished* the marathon in seven hours, 14 minutes. He really meant to, he said. "All those people who sponsored me would have been disappointed if I'd failed and I was running[!] for the Greenwich & Bexley Hospice – I *had* to finish!"

21 AGAIN

Glenn came to see us once he'd recovered a little, to tell us his story and to collect his sponsorship money. Altogether he's raised £700 and when asked how old he was, he grinned "21 again!".

SPONSORS

His sponsors, other than the *Thamesmead People*, were: Glenn's Dad (at Bexleyheath CIU Club), residents of Aspen Green and Leatherbottle Green; Lakeside Health Centre staff; Mr Gresty and Kate at the Tavy Bridge dentists, Heather Pollitt at Taylor, Nelson, Safres Healthcare; Julie Scott at TTL; Thamesmead Library staff; Anne at Glimpsing Green 1o'clock Club; Family Pet Supplies, Bexleyheath and members and parents of Thamesmead Karate Club. Well done, everybody!



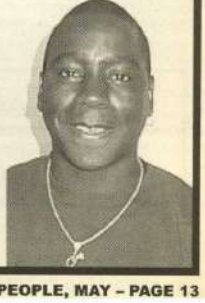


Top, Glenn proudly displaying his medals and, below, a close-up of the medals he'll add to his now considerable collection

Your sport?

Want to get organised?

Talk to Trevor Cross ("Baldy") at **Trust Thamesmead**



check page eight

TLC working 2

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

Further to the item on page three, another case ...

MR X bought a property six years ago, in which he lived with his wife and children.

He got into problems in paying his mortgage and his building society then obtained a possession order, which meant that if he missed any payments at all on his mortgage he would be evicted.

INJURED

Out client was then injured at work and, due to his inability to work, fell behind with his mortgage.

Mr X approached the Thamesmead Law Centre, who contacted the building society, asking them to look sympathetically at Mr X's case.

However, the building society told our client that unless he paid a large sum of money he would be evicted. The society then told the bailiffs to attend our client's house to evict our client.

Thamesmead Law Centre asked the Court to allow our client to remain in the property.

After a disputed hearing, the Judge agreed to use his judgement in our client's favour and allowed our client to remain in the property.

REMAIN

Thamesmead Law Centre has now told our client to apply for disability benefits – this should greatly improve our client's situation and there is every chance of our client remaining in the property.

Anyone doubt the worth of the Thamesmead Law Centre?

East Greenwich Library returns

LBG

EAST Greenwich Library could be open in the next six weeks, under a temporary rescue plan agreed by Greenwich Council. Cllr Peter Challis, the Council's executive member for public services, revealed details of the plan to the full Council meeting on April 27.

The Library, in Woolwich Road, was closed after a structural survey found serious water penetration into the roof.

£300,000

Faced with a potential repair bill of more than £300,000, the Council investigated various options for restoring the service. These included taking over part of the nearby mini town hall, or using a local community centre.

However, the quickest and cheapest option was found to be partitioning the library building and opening that part which was structurally sound.

TEMPORARY

Cllr Challis commented "The Council has worked hard to find a way of reinstating a library service for the residents of lower Charlton and East Greenwich. This is a temporary solution and we will need to develop long term proposals for a modern library and information service in the area in due course."

He explained that the *longer-term plans for a* service in the area will be influenced by wider developments in East Greenwich. The Council is keeping a close eye on a number of development sites which could become available in the near future and which could potentially provide opportunities for an improved library.

Twin Tumps togetherness

JOHN MARSH

IN the afternoon of Palm Sunday, April 16, around 50 members of the Thamesmead & Abbey Wood Christian Community Partnership gathered at the Twin Tumps, Thamesmead, to pray for Thamesmead. The prayers were led by Father Michael Lovell and Pastor Vic Lambert.

SERVICE

The group afterwards walked into the town centre (being led by a donkey, loaned for the occasion), on the way distributing palm crosses and leaflets. On arrival, an open-air service was held, with items by the different churches represented.

The choir of St Paul's led the singing, the Thamesmead Christian Fellowship performed a mime and Emmanuel Church provided a puppet show. A short message was read by Pastor Godfried of Emmanuel Church.

It was an enjoyable occasion and illustrated the unity of the churches within the town.

The donkey behaved impeccably – only on one occasion did it refuse to move, but it was soon persuaded to go on.

Right royal riverside park

LBG

GREENWICH Council was given the necessary royal permission this month to call the new riverside park in Woolwich "Royal Arsenal Gardens". The name was selected by the public from a shortlist of six.

Electronic copies of the digital pictures appearing in the *Thamesmead People* are available by e-mail. Just send an e-mail asking and identifying – and you can have them. Free.

POST BAG

Address letters to **The Editor, The Thamesmead People, 5 Hartslock Drive, Thamesmead SE2 9UR**, with the writer's name and address, stating if these details are to be omitted on printing. Neither the publisher, The Printing House Thamesmead Ltd, nor the editor, necessarily agrees with sentiments expressed in letters printed here but they endeavour to reproduce, within the law and with minimal editorial amendment, all the opinions of the community.

DEADLINE – JUNE 9

DOING NOTHING

Dear Sir, I am writing in regards to an article in the April *Thamesmead People* entitled "News from Broadwaters".

Children in Broadwaters, especially Whinchat Road, have nothing to do. Playing games (*eg*, football) on the streets and the alley walkways between the houses is what they do. They hit the balls on the sides of houses and cause great nuisances.

Some parents/guardians are not taking responsibility for their children to know where they are going and what they are doing. Parents/guardians need to take their children to the designated areas for playing. Just recently a neighbour had his garden wall seriously damaged by youths playing ball games in the alley walkway.

Thamesmead Town Ltd [*Ed: now Gallions Housing Association - see page 11*] on the other hand is doing nothing to stop the nuisances the children are causing, although it has been reported to them on many occasions. Thamesmead Town Ltd could start by narrowing down the alley walkways between the houses, with iron rails, and make them into "turnstile" type walkways for pedestrians.

For example in Whinchat Road, the alley walkways between the houses where the children are playing frequently could be narrowed down to prevent ball games.

The children often-times play on the streets and are narrowly missed by passing vehicles. Something needs to be done before our children are seriously hurt.

I do hope that Thamesmead Town [Ltd] and the officers in charge of Broadwaters take on board the issues and concerns raised by the neighbourhood of Whinchat Road. *Joy Freckleton*

COMMENT 1

Dear Sir, the article "Yet three more years" in the April edition of the *People* does not accurately reflect the nature of the residual function of Thamesmead Town Limited. It is true that it will remain until financial matters such as tax, VAT and outstanding invoices are satisfied. It will be working to revised Memorandum and Articles, which have been requested by the Government Office for London.

It will have a board of five directors, namely Tony Moon, Tony Cox, Jackie Smith, Bill Charnock and Keith Holloway, and Philip Currie will act as Company Secretary. There will be no remuneration for directors.

TTL will hold no assets (other than the finance needed to settle liabilities) and will have no responsibility or authority for running housing, commercial or community functions. These will be dealt with by Gallions, Tilfen and Trust Thamesmead, whose boards are already in place to manage their respective organisations.

The management of Thamesmead Times is not a function of TTL and its directors will have no responsibility for its continuance.

There is, however, one issue that may present some delay in the final "winding-up" of the residual TTL. There has been protracted negotiation with the London Pension Fund Authority to preserve pension rights of TTL employees transferring to the new organisations.

Whilst there has been a satisfactory outcome for those transferring to Gallions and Trust Thamesmead, Tilfen employees are being treated differently. LPFA do not view Tilfen as an eligible body for transfer. To protect the position of those 12 employees TTL will continue to act as employer to those affected and second them to Tilfen. Directors of TTL and Tilfen will continue to work to resolve this situation.

The current deadline for completion is April 28, 2000. The new organisations will then be "in control". The Board of TTL wishes them every success and hope[s] that the community will support them and be actively involved.

Jackie Smith, on behalf of the board

COMMENT 2

Dear Sir, as far as the continuation of the Thamesmead Times is concerned and its dowry, the intention is that the Thamesmead Times will cease to be a "company" newspaper and evolve as an independent, commercially viable community newspaper.

For a period of one year it will be produced under the aegis of Trust Thamesmead (subject to Trust Thamesmead Board approval) funded by its dowry, altering its format and presentation to reflect much more accurately the interests and concerns of Thamesmead residents as a whole. At the end of that year it is on its own.

For too long Thamesmead has been blessed with a "company" newspaper and an "anti-company" newspaper ... really only of interest to the handful of people involved in the incestuous squabble of the pro- and anti-TTL lobbies.

There is no room for either in the bright new post-TTL world.

The new beginning for the Thamesmead Times was initiated by a working party of TTL Elected Directors and later approved by the TTL Board. That working party met on a number of occasions and had the benefit of advice and guidance from a media consultant.

Thamesmead is now undergoing its greatest growth for about 20 years and within the next five may well reach its long-awaited completion as a balanced community. With all the new incoming residents it is essential for Thamesmead to retain its overall, but changing, identity and pursue its community of interests.

A community newspaper, as we expect the Thamesmead Times to become, will have those concerns at its heart and, hopefully, counter the fragmentation that Thamesmead is subjected to from two local authorities, three TTL successor bodies, two (soon to be three) SRBs, *etc*.

A thought ... how about a bit of cross fertilisation, a bit of collaboration, perhaps a pooling of resources and expertise?

Tony Moon, on behalf of the board

COMMENT 3

Dear Sir, ever since the installation of absolute rule at Fort Thamesmead Giant Despair has stalked the town, with good reason, despite the naive assumption that it would be easy to despatch the regime which has been speedily corrected by "Yet three more years!" in April's *Thamesmead People*.

Now it would seem that Giant Fear also bestrides the town, if the increased number of correspondents to this renowned column who are determined to keep below the parapet by using the anonymous style, or adopting a pseudonym, *sobriquet*, *etc*, is an indication.

What are the imagined fears and terrors of these fragile souls, what are they really hiding? Do they fear the authorities or their neighbours – have no fear, although the authorities are no longer on the public's side the midnight knock is still the exception and Thamesmead residents are good, nice people.

The less anonymous correspondence a newspaper publishes, the more its credibility and transparency are enhanced and the larger interests of freedom of speech and honest dealing are promoted in the public forum – in this instance assisting in raising the town from the slough of despond. *Paul Kelliher*

CONTEMPT

Dear Sir, with reference to the TTL tenant's letter in the last edition [April], the writer is broadly correct with the problems of antisocial behaviour.

I feel he/she is unfair on the Police, as they do require to know if there is concrete evidence on crimes. They have responded, in both Bexley and Greenwich, to public concerns with youth crime and disorder as a priority in their plans for this financial year, but they do require information to identify "hot spots".

It is not the Police who placed video cameras in TTL housing areas, it is our private landlord [Ed: now GHA].

Derek Flippance was correct in saying the TTL security contractor was never to do the job of the Police, but they did supplement them in answering less urgent calls to protect TTL property and residents, so we could live in a reasonable state of peace of mind.

The spokesperson for Broadwaters appeared to be making excuses for those antisocial young adults. She claimed there is nothing for teenagers, asking what was going on for Easter – but TTL's "Baldy" claims he puts on events all over Thamesmead.

Nobody will provide football in car parks on fine days and evenings when the nearby recreation parks are empty.

She claims the flats look like Belmarsh and moans about sports cages. Surely with anything provided, safety is a priority and should be sustainable against abuse and destruction.

She made the statement "nothing for the girls, why?". Perhaps the overwhelming majority find positive and constructive leisure pursuits and attend events put on for them by the TTL community trust, who claim over 100 groups.

Perhaps the boredom is due to school absenteeism, as they are unable to understand right from wrong. I did not see an advertisement for the Broadwaters Community Hall or other TTL halls over Easter for teenagers.

Yet it is a minority that causes the problems in society (yes, some do not live in Thamesmead) and it is this group that usually do not receive much encouragement from their parents.

Twice, this Easter period, I went to the town centre and saw the teenagers' play area in the Moorings virtually empty of young folk – also not uncommon at weekends.

To make claims that teenagers are bored, or to blame government, local authorities or TTL with their cut-backs holds little water if the brains do not allow them to respect many facilities provided. It is a waste of new monies being put into the system if they prefer to abuse them and treat provision with contempt.

D Demy

BEST VALUE

Dear Sir, how apt was the front page headline "Crisis" in the last edition [April], highlighting the fraught relations between TTL and the misconceived name of the Interserve company.

Relations have also been very fraught with residents involved with the conversion. Many, if not most, of us had our asbestos survey weeks and months *after* the heat and hot water conversion. Indeed, works in Broadwaters started in September 1999 yet, as admitted by Steven Sitch, the company tabloid did not print a full-page advertisement feature until December. Talk about "the cart before the horse" – is it any wonder there was a shut-down in the works?

It was six weeks after the finish of my conversion when the contracted-out TTL clerk of works visited me and found some work not up to standard. These have still not been done after some four months' later – so much for TTL's customer care policy. The performance of Steven Sitch in his position as special project director can only be described as shameful.

When TTL contracted out the boiler house engineering staff to Brightside it showed they were able to manage or understand maintenance within its organisation or take notice of professional advice except that of overpaid management consultants.

The Thamesmead operation of Brightside is highly regarded by the vast majority of service receivers. It is profit-making, whilst its sister parts of the Birmingham-based organisation, including the North of the Thames operation, are not – which is why the parent company has been put into administration.

It would appear the best option to retain these experienced staff in Thamesmead, and for the best value, is for them to attempt a management buy-out, but don't involve that disaster-prone S Sitch, who is responsible for the Comfort 2000 fiasco.

Ray Hutchins

TARDY 180

Dear Sir, I was interested to read the letter "Those buses" *last month, from* S Ahmed, which draws attention to the notoriously bad and depleted bus service (or dis-service would be a more appropriate description in this case) in many areas of Thamesmead.

Particularly so on the South side, Abbey Wood for instance, and parts of the Erith area, served by the extremely tardy 180 bus route.

This bus service has been the subject of complaints and criticism since February 1999, and again in February of this year.

S Ahmed's letter also complains about the 178 bus route, Woolwich and Eltham service, which used to take in Abbey Wood and Lewisham, which means that people in the Shooters Hill area who want to get to Abbey Wood now have to change buses and pay an additional fare.

Way back in February of this year, following representations to London Transport about the 180 bus service and the fact of LT having " ... acknowledged the problem ... and were taking steps to improve the situation ..." (backwards, it now seems), no surprise, but nothing whatsoever has happened to improve the situation which has got progressively worse, day by day.

Not even a hint as to whether an additional bus service will be run along Harrow Manor Way/Abbey Wood/McLeod Road, which was left high and dry. Just the one bus, 180, left when someone at LT in January last year wielded the "Beeching" axe and "chopped" the 272 bus service that used to run between Thamesmead and Woolwich *via* Harrow Manor Way and McLeod Road, and took the 177 bus service away

Sad star letter

Dear Sir, we would like to take this opportunity to say goodbye to Mr and Mrs Turner from Windrush School. Mr Turner has been Schoolkeeper there for 26 years. He is having to retire owing to changes at Windrush School.

Mr and Mrs Turner have finished up with no home and Mr Turner has lost his job as well. Mr Turner had put a lot of hard work into his job. He also did a lot of work outside school hours, like running the football team.

Mrs Turner was a founder of the 1st Brownie Pack and served on the committee of the Waterways Community Children's Centre. She was a founder-member of this committee and raised cash for the building of this Centre. She is still employed at this Centre and is still fund-raising to date.

Mr and Mrs Turner have to leave their home, which is on school property, by May 1, 2000. They will have no home and Mr Turner will have no job. Neither Thamesmead Town [Ltd] nor Greenwich Council will offer them a place in Thamesmead, where all their family and friends are.

As Jill and John Turner have to leave their home we would just like to wish them all the very best for the future. They will be in Windrush Schoolhouse from May 22 to May 30. If anyone who knows Jill and John would like to call at the Schoolhouse in that week to say their goodbyes, Jill and John will make them more than welcome.

With all our very best wishes for the future and we hope you get your home in Thamesmead.

Mr and Mrs L Gay



Thamesmead Arts Club

Art for All

a Millennium project sponsored by Trust Thamesmead and the Arts Council of Bexley

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Monday and Thursday evenings 7.30 until 10.30pm

Unit 9, Harrow Manor Way, Thamesmead

(first unit under the flyover on Abbey Wood side)

More details from 020 8310 8543 or from Brian De Souza on 020 8244 9035

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Thamesmere Pools, Thamesmead Drive SE28 8RE
Telephone 020 8310 4246
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Thamesmead People

from the Erith side of Thamesmead – Alsike Road route – causing inconvenience and misery to hundreds of people in the South Thamesmead/ Abbey Wood areas.

Waiting for the lone 180 bus serving Abbey Wood it is not unusual to have to wait up to 45 minutes and it's not unusual to find them overcrowded *when one does arrive* – standing-room only being the order of the day most times!

But it is the people in the Abbey Wood-McLeod Road area who are affected most with just the 180 bus service passing through there. It is disgraceful!

Our local MP John Austin, following the problems of Harris Bus, must intervene and deal with the situation which is fast becoming an outcry all over the Abbey Wood area and parts of South Thamesmead.

LT should be made to face up to its responsibilities to the public and ensure that adequate, regular, bus services are provided in London for the public who need and depend on these services. LT must also ensure that proper and fair consideration is given to the public when awarding the franchises to the various operators and listen to, and deal with, complaints arising from bad or depleted bus services, and *improve* them!

Denis Thompson-Mason

THANKS 1

Dear Sir, many thanks for the computer disk of the Irish Dancing. I now have two lovely prints of my granddaughter.

As you requested, I have sent a cheque to Gary Redding's Chest of Hope at Respond, explaining the reason.

I just wanted to let you know I had received the disk and how grateful I am for the help I have received from you all.

Yvonne Calder

THANKS 2

Dear Sir, the Greenwich & Bexley Cottage Hospice is very grateful to all the friends of Tom Chambers who kindly sent donations to the Hospice in his memory.

These generous donations will help us continue to offer our very special care. Thank you once again for thinking of us at this difficult time.

Jim Bennett, appeals director

THANKS 3

Copy of letter to Ted Claridge after a Community Workers' Lunch in Thamesmead

Dear Ted, thank you for your kind donation raised at your lunch. The Forget-me-not Appeal will enable the Hospice to expand its services to meet the needs of terminally ill residents of the London boroughs of Greenwich and Bexley.

The increase in patient beds, the enlarged and enhanced Day Hospice facility and the development of the support services will be greatly appreciated by everyone. Your support will help us reach our appeal target in the shortest time possible and to bring our plans into operation earlier than we first envisaged.

Jim Bennett

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INFORMATION

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FREE LEGAL ADVICE

From the new Thamesmead Law Centre

Free and Independent Legal Advice for residents

To make an appointment either call in to St Paul's Ecumenical Centre, Bentham Road, Thamesmead between 10 and 1 any weekday or call 020 8311 0555

Domestic violence 24-hour Helpline number
0870 599 5443

Community resources

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION RESOURCE CENTRE

For tenants and charge-payers of the Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, Abbey Wood. Open Mondays 1-4 and 5-8, Tuesdays 2-6 and Thursdays 10-1. Residents interested in starting tenants' and residents' associations contact: Tenant Participation Officer Linda Nash on **020 8320 3451.**

THE VILLAGE HALL, BROADWATERS

Karate Tuesdays 6.30-9.30pm. Karate Fridays 6.30-9.30pm. Fountain of Hope Church every Sunday 10.30am-1.30pm plus Sunday school. Bingo Friday evenings 7–9 (got to have sense of humour!). Toddlers Group 1.30–3.30 Thursdays, Stephanie Carter, your Health Visitor, will be on hand. Please book adults' parties in plenty of time. For bookings and information, ring Jean on **8 473 3810.**

ARNOTT CLUB ROOM

under the Moorings Club. Thamesmead Disabled and Senior Citizens' Club Meets every Monday, Wednesday and Friday. Bingo each day: Mondays open at 7pm, eyes down at 8; Wednesdays open at 1pm, eyes down at 2 and Fridays open at 7pm, eyes down at 8, contact Anne on 310 1994.

BEXLEY CENTRE FOR THE UNEMPLOYED

Trinity Place, Broadway, Bexleyheath Kent DA6 7AY. **020 8310 3187.** Open 10.30am – 3.30pm. Mondays to Wednesdays open to all. Thursdays, women only and lone parents. Fridays, Youth Project (under 25s). Ring for FREE courses.

ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

Thamesmead Town and Abbey Wood Branch. Contact: Kath or Rab Moffat on **020 8310 1341** for help and advice.

Religious groups

NEW COVENANT CHURCH

(Thamesmead Centre) invite you to join them for a time of worship and dynamic teachings. Venue: Castillon Primary School, Copperfield Road, off Crossway, Thamesmead, London SE28 8QA. Regular Church Activities: Sunday Worship,10.00–1.00pm; Tuesday, Bible study, 7.00–9pm; Friday, Home Groups, 7.00–9.00pm.

TRIUMPHANT CHARISMATIC BAPTIST CHURCH

Weekly services: Sundays 2–5pm, Frdays 7.30–9.30pm, Venue Clockhouse Community Centre, Defiance Walk, Woolwich SE28 5QL. Tel 020 8311 8366/0961 175960.

Playgroups

TAVY BRIDGE PLAYGROUP

Will your child will be 2 years 9 months old soon? If so, he or she could then start Playgroup. Pop in and put your child(s) name(s) down. Phone Jan am on **8311 4093**, pm on **8310 6312**, for more details.

LITTLE STARS

Little Stars: after school/school holidays childcare, Greenmead Club, 1 Lime Row, Thamesmead, DA18 4DW, telephone **07941 081697.**

Advice and support groups

VICTIM SUPPORT

A local, independent organisation, working for victims of crime **020 8854 1113.**

FOUR-LEGGED FRIENDS

Four-Legged Friends Rescue Centre, Southmere Park, **off Hartslock Drive.** Thamesmead's animal resource and rescue centre, in need of support, donations and and helpers. Contact **020 8311 5086.**

IRISH IN GREENWICH, LEGAL ADVICE

The Irish in Greenwich Project. Free legal advice surgeries on first and second Tuesdays of each month. 24–24a Greens End, Woolwich SE18. Telephone **020 8854 4466.**

FAMILY SERVICE UNIT

1 and 3 Maran Way, Thamesmead. Family advice and support, anti-poverty project and support for young families. Contact **020 8310 6570.**

BIRCHMERE CRECHE AND ONE O'CLOCK CLUB

Birchmere Park (rear of Disraeli Close). Birchmere Creche, 9.30–11.30am, Monday to Friday (term time). Birchmere One O'clock Club, 1–4pm, Mondays to Fridays. Nursery Equipment Loan Scheme, Mondays and Wednesdays 1–3pm. contact Linda Dalley on **020 8310 1500**, extension **450**.

Advice sources

ADVICE AT THE BRIDGE

at Tavy Bridge. Know-how and support for young people 16–19. Call Wednesdays 4.30–7 or ring **020 8311 0971.**

BEXLEY COUNCIL TAX

The telephone number for Bexley Housing Benefit, Council Tax Benefit and Council Tax account enquiries is now **0845 3023200**, charged at local rate

INLAND REVENUE ADVICE

Woolwich 1 and 2 Tax Offices are at Crown Building, 48 Woolwich New Road, Woolwich SE18 6HE. Staff are available to give advice on all Income Tax, Corporation Tax and Capital Gains Tax matters on **020 8333 4600.**

GREENWICH BENEFITS ADVICE

The Greenwich Welfare Rights Service Advice Line for Social Security benefits is **020 8312 5565.**

GREENWICH CONSUMER ADVICE

For help and advice Greenwich Council's Consumer Advice Line ring **020 8312 5558.**

Activity groups

IRISH GREENWICH PENSIONERS' ASSOCIATION

meets on the first and third Wednesday of every month, from 2pm onwards, at the Woolwich Catholic Social Club. 55 years+ all welcome. Activities include bingo, music, refreshments, outings, a chance to meet other people and socialise. For further information contact the Irish in Greenwich Project on **020 8854 4466.**

TRADITIONAL IRISH MUSIC

Tin whistle classes. The Irish in Greenwich Project music classes, Monday evenings, from 6.30 to 8pm at West Greenwich House. Suit beginner and intermediate levels. Cost £1.50 a session (child/cons) and £3 adults. All welcome. 141 Greenwich High Road. West Greenwich House, 3 minutes' walk from Greenwich Railway Station and on bus route 177. Telephone **020 8854 4466.**

BEXLEY U3A

Bexley University of the Third Age. "There are no strangers here, only friends who haven't yet met." Contact Ray and Rene Goater, group liaison on **020 8300 7621.**

2ND THAMESMEAD SCOUT GROUP

Want some fun and adventure and a chance to meet new friends? For those aged 6–20 and meeting at Turnp 53 (near Hawksmoor School) Contact Pat Robinson on **020 8473 0378.**

Halls for hire

HALL FOR HIRE

Hire The Village Hall, Broadwaters - the Hall for children's parties - why have the mess at home? Book adults' parties in plenty of time – bookings/ information, ring Jean on **8 473 3810.**

HALL FOR HIRE

Need a venue? The Thamesmead Community College - a range of facilities for hire. Call Jenny Watson on **020 8310 0111.**

HALL FOR HIRE

Jubilee Management Committee. Reasonable rates of hire. For further information call the Lettings Officer on **8312 2784** and leave a contact name and number on the answer phone.

ELECTED REPRESENTATIVES

JOHN AUSTIN, MP for Erith & Thamesmead, surgeries each month, contact number 020 7219 5195.

NICK RAYNSFORD, MP for Greenwich & Woolwich, contact 020 8853 1261/020 7219 5895 for appointment.

PETER KOTZ and **PETER BROOKS**, Moorings Councillors (Greenwich), surgery in Creche at Thamesmere Leisure Centre, first Saturday of each month, 10.30-11.30am and on third Friday of each month 6.30-7.30pm. 020 8311 5673 and 020 8310 9599 respectively.

DON AUSTEN and **JOHN WAKEFIELD**, Glyndon Councillors (Greenwich), surgery at Heronsgate School, Broadwaters, 9.30-11am, first Saturday of each month. Ring Don on 0181 854 8833 (answerphone) or 0468 908628.

DONNA BRIANT, **MIKE FRENCH** and **CHRIS BALL**, Thamesmead East Councillors (Bexley), surgery in Thames-

Don't forget to get your copy or contribution in to the *People* by the 15th of the month! Please?

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